



21 MIRRORS

D. Ashedkar

21 Mirrors

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First published by Cognastra 2025

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First edition

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*For the ones who cracked open, not because they were weak — but
because light needed a way in.*

For the ones who feel too much, love too hard, and still stay.

You were never broken. You were becoming.

This is for the ache that turned to alchemy.

For the mirrors that showed you more than just your face.

I remembered you before you remembered yourself.

- D. Taskhedkar

AS I work on my shadows...
....you release yours.

Foreword



This book is not meant to be devoured in one sitting.

It is meant to be *felt*.

Held. Reflected in. Returned to.

21 Mirrors is a collection of soul portraits. Each chapter stands alone as a fictional therapy session — a single moment in the life of someone navigating the weight of a mind they do not yet fully understand.

They come to Angelique, a psychologist with an unusual gift: she sees what others bury. Her presence is not loud. But it shifts things.

Though rooted in psychological accuracy, this work carries the shimmer of something deeper — an undercurrent of mysticism that runs through the sessions like a pulse. Here, evidence-based therapy quietly meets the spiritual. Neuroscience brushes shoulders with the soul. And the healing is not always linear.

These mirrors are not arranged by intensity, gender, or outcome. You may read them in order, or choose a chapter by title, theme, or feeling. Wherever you begin, trust that it's where you were meant to start.

You'll meet people here — some broken, some brilliant, most both — who might remind you of someone you love. Or of the parts of yourself you've hidden away. Each chapter invites you to witness, not diagnose. To observe, not fix. To listen with the ears of the heart.

This book was created for empaths, overthinkers, survivors, artists, seekers — anyone who has ever asked, “What’s wrong with me?” and quietly hoped the answer was, *Nothing at all. You’re just carrying too much.*

May these mirrors help you lay it down.

Preface



21 Mirrors was never planned.

It arrived — like a hush in the middle of noise — when I had almost forgotten how to keep going.

Each chapter came as a visitation. A whisper. A soul knocking gently.

They weren't just characters — they were truths I'd buried, parts I had lost, or lives I might have lived had things turned just slightly.

Some of them, I met in dreams. Some, in silence. Some, during a time when death sat close — and something in me crossed a threshold it never fully came back from.

There was a season where grief hollowed me out.

Someone I loved left this world without warning. A little creature who was family followed soon after.

Everything I believed in collapsed — until the only thing left was the work. The stories.

The healing.

And slowly, mirror by mirror, I found pieces of myself again.

Through psychology, I found understanding.

Through mysticism, I found meaning.

Through these pages, I found a way to alchemize pain into presence.

This book is not just fiction. It's a map.

For the ones who feel *too much*.

For the ones who almost left, but didn't.

For the quiet ones who carry lifetimes inside them and call it "just a phase."

For the ones who have heard a voice that the world says isn't real — but it kept them alive.

May each chapter meet you where you are.

And may one mirror, if not many, help you remember who you are becoming.

Trigger Warning



21 Mirrors contains emotionally intense depictions of:

childhood abuse, sexual trauma, emotional neglect, self-harm, suicide ideation, substance use, psychopathy, and grief.

Though fictional, these stories reflect real emotional wounds — some still healing, some still raw.

This book is not meant to retraumatize. It's meant to witness. To soften. To offer mirrors.

If any chapter feels too heavy, it's okay to pause.

Take care of your heart as you read.

Some mirrors are sharp. Others heal.

All of them are human.

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Prologue



A New Day.

A new sun shone through as she slid the dark brown curtains aside, letting the hopeful rays in. She stood there, taking in the view.

She loved this view.

She had *paid* for this view — in cash, and in kind.

A smile crept onto her face as she thought about all the highs and lows that had plucked her from a regular life and placed her here.

I'm exactly where I was meant to be, she thought, feeling her heart swell.

She moved through the room with a quiet deliberateness, replacing dry flowers with fresh ones, lighting a stick of lavender incense. She closed her eyes and let the smoke coil around her, whispering to corners unseen.

The rituals weren't just for the space — they were for her too.

Little acts of devotion to forces she never named out loud.

She knew she was on a mission: to care for the souls that would find their way to her — those sent not just by

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circumstance, but by something deeper, older.

The heretics called them Shamans.

The believers called them Mediums.

The realists called them Psychologists.

All of them called her **Miss Angelique.**

But she had other names, too — whispered ones, in places where the veil ran thin.

One

The Girl who felt Invisible



Crrreeaaaakk.

The door swept open tenderly, and in walked a mousy-looking teenager, her eyes so big they seemed to swallow the rest of her face. She hovered for a second, then spotted Angelique seated across the room.

Angelique locked eyes with her, offering a warm, effortless smile.

"I guess I'm your two o'clock appointment," the girl said with a nervous laugh, her voice thin but brave.

The first thing Angelique sensed was the air — tight, crumpled, as if the very room was holding its breath. The girl seemed to take up as little space as possible, shrinking in on herself, as if even breathing cost too much.

Angelique shrugged the sensation off and glanced down at the file on her desk.

"Ah. You must be Freida," she said kindly. "Hope it wasn't

too hard to find the place. Please, make yourself at home.”

She gestured toward the plush sofa beside her chair.

Freida slumped down, dropping her tiny backpack with a soft thud. “Hello, ma’am. I heard about you from a friend I made on Insta...and when I thought I needed to talk to someone, your name just...popped into my head. So I thought I’d give it a try.”

First timers always tried to overcompensate by filling up the silences with small talk. They sometimes have this need of seeming confident or ‘with-it’ to jump through the hoop of taboos. Angelique found this to be adorable in people. She always liked to let them take just enough space in the beginning to not seem coddling. Freida seemed like the type that would not react well to coddling.

“That’s good to know. I’m glad you found me,” Angelique said, her voice easy, unhurried.

“So. Let’s start from the beginning.

Tell me about you — what you love, hate, dream about. Your family, your days. Anything you want to share.”

She picked up her notepad, casually ready to scribble if needed, but made no move to rush the girl.

Freida inhaled deeply — the kind of breath you take before stepping onto a stage — and launched into a clearly-rehearsed monologue. “I’m Freida. Nineteen. Art major in college. My parents are techies — pretty cool ones, actually. They’re super supportive. I also have an older sister. She’s... okay. We don’t really get along.” She shot Angelique a mischievous smirk — a flash of spirit behind all that shrinking — and Angelique returned it with a knowing grin.

The Girl who felt Invisible

Therapy always went smoother when the client felt you were on their side.

There was a lull in the air after that. Silence bloomed — but it wasn't empty. A silence so full of unsaid thoughts, like a lingering image of hooks boring holes into the fabric of her consciousness trying to get a hold of her understanding. She looked up at Angelique for a second. Her features untroubled in that instant as if taking a leap into the unknown.

Angelique uncrossed her legs to stretch them a bit.

That seemed to do the trick.

Freida inhaled sharply through her nose, then let her shoulders slump at last.

"I'm here for... body dysmorphia," she blurted, rushing the words like they might evaporate if she hesitated. "I don't feel comfortable in my skin. I hate the shape of my body. It's like... it just won't grow right. Clothes don't fit me the way they do on others." She stifled a congested sniff but ended up choking and crying out loud.

Angelique leaned forward slightly, picking up the box of tissues from the coffee table and offering it across the space between them — a bridge built gently, not forced. Freida took a few of them and wiped her nose and face.

Freida grabbed a few tissues, wiping at her face in quick embarrassed swipes.

When she blinked around the room again, it was with a dazed, startled sort of look — like she'd only just realized she'd let herself be seen.

"That's perfectly okay, Freida.

Sometimes just letting the hurt out — giving it air — is the first real step toward healing.

21 *Mirrors*

"You're allowed to sit with it for a while." Angelique's voice was calm, grounding.

She watched the girl breathe — shaky, but freer now.

Angelique wanted to hug the girl sobbing in front of her. Her lack of self-image, subdued confidence in herself and the weight of crippling societal pressure on this young girl made Angelique feel obsidian.

Part of Angelique, the part she usually kept tucked away, stirred in her chest.

She felt the crack in Freida's spirit, the bruised threads of a young soul stretched thin under the grinding machinery of beauty standards and self-loathing.

There was work to be done here.

But for now, Angelique simply sat — steady, silent — holding the space open.

* * *

The session progressed with eventual drops and highs after that. Freida talked about a few instances such as how she avoided wearing certain type of clothes, preferred to wear baggy clothes and tiptoed around her feelings of envy when it came to looking at other girls. There was a particular situation where the guy that she was crushing on always liked the pictures of girls who were curvier and treated her with passivity.

This poor soul! She must confront a major belief block at such a young age.

Angelique shifted slightly in her chair, softening her posture further, almost melting into the space — offering it freely to

The Girl who felt Invisible

the girl across from her.

“Freida,” she said gently, “can you remember the first time you noticed feeling uncomfortable in your body? A particular moment, or maybe... a feeling?”

Freida tucked a lock of hair behind her ear, fidgeting with the frayed hem of her sleeve. “I think... I think it’s always been there,” she said, voice barely above a whisper. “But it got worse after my sister started posting about me.”

Angelique tilted her head slightly, encouraging her to go on.

“She’s a fitness influencer now. You know... abs, waist-snatching edits, gym selfies,” Freida said with a sad laugh. “When we were younger, she would always say stuff like, ‘you’re so tiny, you look like a stick insect!’ or ‘you’ll never grow curves like me.’ I laughed it off then.” Her voice cracked, almost imperceptibly. “But now... it’s like I’m stuck. Like my body’s betraying me by not becoming ‘enough.’”

A beat of silence passed between them — a silence so alive, it buzzed at the edges.

Angelique’s fingers gently tapped the armrest once, twice.

She could feel it again — that knowing, the soft pull in her chest.

The sister’s voice still lived inside Freida, an unseen puppeteer. The battle wasn’t just with mirrors or clothes; it was with a spectral voice that told her she was unfinished, incomplete.

She leaned forward, just a little. “It sounds like part of you is carrying someone else’s definition of beauty,” Angelique said quietly. “As if you’ve been trying to meet a standard that was never yours to begin with.”

Freida’s eyes brimmed with tears again, but this time she didn’t try to hide them. “Yeah,” she breathed. “It’s like... I don’t

even know what I like anymore.”

Angelique offered a small, understanding smile. “We can work on that. Little by little,” she said. “Reclaiming your body — and your story — from anyone else who tried to write it for you.”

Freida let out a shaky laugh. “Sounds like a lot of work.”

“It is,” Angelique agreed. “But the good news is, you don’t have to do it alone.”

She made a few notes on her pad — small things Freida had said — but most of the work, she knew, wouldn’t come from scribbled words.

It would come from being present, from listening to what wasn’t being said.

As Freida gathered her things, Angelique tore off a small sheet from her writing pad and scribbled something quickly.

“Before you go,” she said, handing the paper to Freida, “I want you to try something this week.”

Freida took the note with a wary glance.

It simply said:

Notice one thing about your body each day that helps you — not how it looks, but what it does for you. Write it down if you can.

“You don’t have to love yourself overnight,” Angelique said with a reassuring smile. “We’re just starting by noticing. Can you try that?”

Freida nodded slowly, her fingers tightening around the piece of paper like a lifeline. “Yeah... I think I can do that.”

“Good,” Angelique said warmly. “We’ll talk about what you notice next time.”

The Girl who felt Invisible

As she stood to walk Freida to the door, a feeling of lightness — tentative but real — seemed to rise in the room.

Just before stepping out, Freida turned back, hesitating. “Miss Angelique... how did you know what to say? I never said anything about my sister until today.”

Angelique simply smiled, a spark of mischief in her dark eyes.

“Some things,” she said, “are whispered to those who know how to listen.”

And with that, the door creaked softly closed behind Freida — leaving Angelique in the golden haze of late afternoon, the scent of lavender still curling in the air.

Two

The Boy Who Couldn't Breathe



It was too early to feel this exhausted, but that's what anxiety does. It doesn't care if it's 10 a.m. on a Tuesday or 3 a.m. in the dead of night. It arrives unannounced, settles in your chest like a stone, and then pretends like it was always there.

Riaan stood just outside the therapy centre, earbuds in but no music playing. Just a half-baked attempt at pretending the world wasn't swallowing him whole. He hated that his palms were already sweaty. Hated that his mind was already racing ahead to all the things he could say wrong.

His appointment with *her* was at 10:15. The woman his best friend swore by—this soft-spoken psychologist who didn't ask you to spill your guts in one go but somehow made you want to.

He checked his reflection in the blacked-out phone screen—puffy eyes, same oversized hoodie. “You look fine,” he muttered to himself. Lying is a soft skill.

The Boy Who Couldn't Breathe

He walked in.

* * *

Angelique had a habit of not looking up right away when a client entered. It wasn't intentional avoidance—it was space-giving. Letting people arrive with their own rhythm. The sound of the door clicking shut, the shuffle of feet on polished floor. These small details said more than most people's words.

She felt him before she saw him.

The air in the room suddenly felt like it weighed a ton. The heaviness wasn't dramatic though. It was the kind that whispered, *I'm tired of fighting the same war in my head every morning.*

When she finally looked up, Riaan had already sat down.

His eyes flicked around the room quickly- anxious minds scan for danger, even in safe spaces.

"Riaan?" she said, with a gentle nod.

He gave a tight-lipped smile; the kind people use when they're trying not to be rude but are too wound up to mean it.

"I don't really know how to start," he admitted.

"That's okay," Angelique said. "You just did."

She didn't reach for her notepad yet. Instead, she tilted her head slightly- noticing the way he held his breath while waiting to speak.

An image of a balloon stretched too tight, just about to burst popped into her mind out of nowhere.

Angelique waited until the silence settled between them—not uncomfortable, but open.

"I feel like I'm always running behind something," Riaan said finally. "Work deadlines. Rent. My friends. I mean, I'm not

even late-late... just constantly... catching up.”

His voice cracked a little at the end, as if even saying it out loud exhausted him.

She nodded slowly. “What happens in your body when you feel like you’re falling behind?”

He blinked. That wasn’t the question he expected.

“My chest... tightens. Like someone’s pulling a drawstring around it. My stomach turns into a pit. Sometimes my hands go cold. Like my body thinks I’m about to be attacked.”

“Even when it’s just an email?” she asked, not to dismiss him—but to reflect the absurdity of it.

He chuckled dryly. “Yeah. Or when someone replies ‘ok.’ No emoji. Just that one word. Suddenly my heart’s doing back flips and I’m trying to figure out what I did wrong.”

“Do you always feel like something’s about to go wrong?”

He paused. “Not always... just often enough that I don’t remember what calm feels like.”

Angelique leaned back slightly. “And when do you notice it the most?”

He rubbed his temples. “When I wake up. When I go to bed. When I open my banking app. When someone I like takes too long to text back. When I think about how much my parents spent on my education and I’m still making ₹30,000 a month doing freelance gigs that I hate.”

“And relationships?”

He sighed. “Don’t even get me started. If I like someone, I overthink every move. If they like me, I wonder if they’ll get bored. If they leave, I feel like I can’t breathe. And if they stay, I feel guilty for not being... stable enough for them.”

Angelique’s eyes softened. “That’s a lot to carry.”

“Yeah,” Riaan said, voice low. “It is.”

The Boy Who Couldn't Breathe

* * *

Angelique hadn't spoken for the last two minutes. She didn't need to. The room was already doing half the work.

Riaan sat on the edge of the grey corduroy couch like he was expecting it to vanish under him — hands clutched in a death grip, a tremor flickering along his left knee, like a clock ticking on borrowed calm. Angelique knew this silence. Not the awkward kind, but the kind that asked you to *listen* deeper.

She watched his chest — not moving evenly. There was a shallow rise and a stuttered fall. People like Riaan didn't breathe as much as they negotiated with their lungs.

"Do you always sit like that?" she asked softly.

Riaan blinked, caught off guard. "Like what?"

"Like you're ready to run. Or vanish."

A small, ironic chuckle. "Feels safer that way."

"Safer than what?"

His mouth opened. Then closed. The words hadn't lined up yet.

Angelique leaned back into her chair, letting the space hold him gently. No rush. No poking. She waited like she was waiting for rain. Certain it would come.

"I'm just... tired," he finally said. "Like I'm always late to some finish line, even if I started first."

Something in Angelique's chest tugged — that invisible thread again. She scribbled a note in her mind, not her notebook. **Time. Pressure. Worth. Delay.**

She glanced at the beaded bracelet on his wrist — tight against the skin. One of those evil-eye bands. Not for faith. For insurance.

"Do you feel like you're failing?" she asked.

Riaan flinched. *Bingo.*

"My parents don't say it out loud," he said. "But it's there. In the pauses. In the way they ask if I've 'figured anything out yet.' They say they're proud but then forward job openings on WhatsApp like it's a reflex."

Angelique smiled — a warm one, not the kind that dims pain. "WhatsApp job links. The new age love language of brown parents."

That made him laugh. A real one, this time.

"You're funny", he said and for a tiny flicker of a second Angelique saw the little kid in him who loves to laugh. Then, just as quickly as it had arrived, it passed making the air suddenly feel a bit denser.

"They think I'm... too sensitive. I feel everything. If I don't text back, they spiral. If I'm quiet at dinner, they assume I'm hiding something."

"Are you?"

He looked up. Met her eyes. "No. I just don't know what to say anymore."

Angelique's hands remained clasped together in her lap, fingertips pressed gently, like she was tuning into a frequency. She didn't need details yet. She needed *textures*.

"What's the first thing you remember being afraid of?" she asked.

"Crowds," he said quickly. "Fairs. Bazaars. I always felt like I'd be swallowed whole."

"And now?"

"Now it's... everything. Waking up. Opening emails. Running into someone I know at the grocery store. *Phone calls.*"

He said that last one like it had teeth.

Angelique nodded slowly. "You've built an entire life around

not being seen, haven't you?"

"I want to be seen," he said. "Just... not *misunderstood*."

There it was again. The invisible thread. Angelique followed it with her mind — spiralling back to moments. Riaan was someone who'd grown up being told he was "too much" or "too quiet" in the wrong ways. Probably the sensitive boy in a class full of loud boys. The one who cried easily. The one who wasn't allowed to.

She made another mental note: **Repressed masculinity. Emotional shame. Over-adaptation.**

Angelique's voice dropped lower. "Anxiety, at its core, is just the body trying to protect us from memory. Sometimes it's not about what happened — but what your nervous system *remembers*."

Riaan's posture softened. His shoulders dropped just enough to notice.

"I just... I want it to stop," he said. "The panic attacks. The constant future simulations in my head. The shaking. My friends don't even know. They think I'm just flaky."

Angelique nodded. "And what would happen if they *did* know?"

He went quiet. Then whispered, "Maybe they'd leave."

The sentence floated in the space like a confession soaked in shame.

Angelique didn't flinch. She never did. "That tells me you've already been left before."

Riaan looked at her — eyes wide with the kind of astonishment that only comes when someone names something you hadn't dared to admit to yourself.

She leaned forward slightly now, energy shifting from grounded to *engaged*. This was the part where she taught people

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how to return to their own bodies.

“Here’s what we’re going to do,” she said gently. “Today, you’re going to start a *Panic Diary*. No filters. Every time you feel that tightening in your chest, or that sinking in your stomach — note it down. Where you were. What you were doing. What your body felt like. What you thought you were afraid of. No edits. Just patterns.”

Riaan blinked. “That sounds... intense.”

“It’s not homework,” she said with a smirk. “It’s field research. You’re the subject and the scientist.”

He smiled. “That actually sounds kind of cool.”

She grinned back. “Good. Because the only way out of anxiety is through *familiarity*. You can’t run from a ghost you’ve never looked in the eye.”

They sat in that soft hum of afterglow — when a truth is aired out and no longer festering.

As the session wound down, Angelique glanced at her notes. So much left to unpack. Family pressure. Emotional avoidance. Masculinity. Sensory overwhelm. And underneath it all, this tender, brilliant, anxious boy trying so hard to earn his right to exist.

“Bye ma’am”, he said with the tiny hint of a real smile unlike the tight-lipped masquerade he had on before. She waved back with a smile of her own.

As Riaan left the room, she whispered under her breath:

“May you remember that panic is not your enemy.

It’s just your inner child calling for oxygen.”

* * *

As Riaan stepped out into the sunlit corridor, something odd

The Boy Who Couldn't Breathe

happened.

For a split second — barely more than a flicker — he felt a rush of warmth bloom at the centre of his chest. Like someone had placed a gentle hand over his heart. Not heavy, not urgent. Just... known.

He blinked. The feeling was gone.

Across the room, Angelique's gaze lingered on the chair where he had sat moments ago. She reached for the smooth onyx pendant that always rested at her throat, thumb brushing over it like a compass finding north.

She'd felt it too. The presence. Brief, but unmistakable.

Some clients came in carrying trauma.

Others... carried echoes. And Riaan's?

His soul wasn't just anxious — it was echoing the quiet ache of a wound carried through generations, still waiting to be heard.

Three

The Woman Who Was Always Waiting



The waiting room had been unusually still today. Not quite—still. Like the kind of silence that hums with the memory of something ancient.

Angelique adjusted the position of the pale blue cushion behind her back. The scent of burnt sage from earlier still clung to the air, stubborn as memory. She didn't mind. Today's client always brought a certain energy with her—a hollowness that echoed.

The clock read 4:01 p.m. She was late, but that didn't worry Angelique. *Grievers often walk slower*. Sometimes not in feet, but in thought. As if time stopped for them, and they never truly caught up.

When the door creaked open, Angelique didn't look up immediately. She didn't need to. She felt it.

The grief entered first.

The Woman Who Was Always Waiting

Then Meera followed.

Her presence wasn't frail—but it had faded. Like a photograph left too long in the sun. She wore a charcoal grey kurta; her hair tied back with little care. No kajal. No perfume. Just the scent of rain-soaked earth and resignation.

She sat down like someone who'd done this before—not out of habit, but out of exhaustion.

"Hi," Meera said simply.

Angelique looked up and nodded. "Hi, Meera. I'm glad you made it."

Meera gave a ghost of a smile. "Didn't want to cancel again. He would've hated that."

Angelique's gaze didn't flinch. "You're not here for him."

"I know," she said, "but sometimes it still feels like I am."

A long pause. Angelique noted the way Meera's fingers rubbed over the edge of her ring finger—the one that used to hold a promise. There was no ring anymore. But muscle memory is a funny thing. It remembers even when we don't want it to.

"Today marks how long?" Angelique asked softly.

"Three years. Four months. Six days," Meera replied without thinking.

Angelique didn't write that down. It was already etched into Meera's nervous system.

* * *

Angelique watched Meera's shoulders. They didn't slump so much as *fold inward*, like she was trying to collapse into herself but still stay upright for the world's sake. That tension... it was familiar. The kind that takes years to name.

21 Mirrors

"I've been dreaming of him again," Meera said after a while.

Angelique didn't speak. The sentence wasn't a statement—it was a thread. You pull too early, it snaps.

"Not like before," Meera continued, her eyes locked on a spot near Angelique's shoulder, as if someone stood there. "This time, he's not saying anything. He just... watches me. Always from a distance. Like he's waiting for *me* to say something."

Angelique's breath caught—but she made no sound. She *felt* it too. A shift in the temperature. Just a dip. Barely perceptible, unless you were tuned into it.

"What do you think he's waiting for?" she asked gently.

Meera swallowed. "Forgiveness maybe. Or for me to stop being angry that he died."

A pause.

"Is that fucked up? To be angry at someone who left?"

Angelique leaned in slightly. "Not at all. Anger is part of grief's disguise. Sometimes the only way we can hold on is to keep blaming them for leaving."

Meera gave a dry laugh. "I don't even know what I'm waiting for anymore. Closure? A sign? A rebirth? I've prayed. I've fasted. I've read every spiritual book I could get my hands on. But nothing fills the hole."

Angelique nodded slowly, sensing the sacred ache beneath her words. "You're not trying to fill the hole," she said. "You're trying to keep it open. Because closing it feels like betrayal."

Meera's breath hitched.

The words landed somewhere deep—beneath the rational mind, beneath coping mechanisms. *Where truth lives without language.*

She sat very still for a moment. Then she whispered, "I sleep with his t-shirt. Still. It doesn't smell like him anymore, but I

The Woman Who Was Always Waiting

pretend.”

Angelique’s heart squeezed. Not from pity—from resonance. She had worked with grief for years, but this kind... this was the kind that makes time stand still. The kind that eats through the seams of a soul.

“Meera,” Angelique said, her voice a warm hush, “where do you feel the ache most in your body?”

Meera didn’t even think. She placed her hand over her sternum. “Right here. Always here. Like a hole in my chest that doesn’t bleed, but it burns.”

Angelique closed her eyes for a second. When she opened them, they glistened—but not from tears. From presence.

“Would you be willing,” she said carefully, “to write him a letter this week?”

Meera blinked. “I’ve done that before.”

“I know,” Angelique nodded. “But not like this. This time, write it as if *you’re the one who stayed*, and he’s the one who needs to hear how the world looks without him in it. Not a letter of loss. A letter of witness.”

Meera’s lip trembled. “That... sounds cruel.”

“It’s not cruel,” Angelique said gently. “It’s sacred honesty. The kind that lets both souls breathe.”

They sat in that quiet hum again. That *otherworldly* space Angelique was so good at opening without saying much. The room always changed when a wound was finally seen without being rushed to be fixed.

* * *

The session had technically ended fifteen minutes ago.

But Meera hadn’t moved.

21 Mirrors

She sat curled up on the couch, one hand clutching her stomach like grief had punched her there, the other shielding her face as if her tears were something shameful.

"I'm sorry," she said, voice cracking. "I just... I thought I was better."

Angelique didn't move right away. Then, quietly, she rose and knelt beside Meera, placing a hand gently over her clenched fist.

The sobs kept coming. Angelique said nothing. She knew this wasn't the kind of pain you fixed. It was the kind you *witnessed*.

"There is no better," Angelique said softly. "There's only before, and after. And the bridge we learn to walk barefoot."

Meera continued to sob. It tore through the air like something primal—raw and echoing. The sound of someone realizing they might never be held again by the one they loved.

After a few minutes, she stood up, walked over to the small table by the window, and lit a lavender candle—her quiet offering to the energy in the room and provide Meera some much needed solace.

The flame caught, wavering as if it, too, knew something sacred had just been released.

"You're not broken," she said, her voice steady. "You're in the middle of remembering how to live without forgetting."

When Meera's breathing finally slowed, Angelique exhaled a slow, long breath as if to release the emotions she had just witnessed.

"Grief," she said gently, "is love with nowhere to go."

Meera looked up, eyes swollen and tired. "But it keeps coming back."

Angelique nodded. "Because love like that doesn't expire. It

The Woman Who Was Always Waiting

just changes its shape.”

Meera inhaled shakily. “It’s been three years.”

“And still fresh,” Angelique replied. “Because it wasn’t a small love. It carved you wide open.”

Meera rubbed her chest absentmindedly. “I don’t want to forget him.”

“You won’t. Healing isn’t forgetting. It’s remembering without collapsing.”

The candle’s flame flickered gently. Meera looked at it.

“I don’t know who I am without being the woman who was waiting for him.”

Angelique smiled softly. “Then maybe it’s time to meet the woman who *survived* him.”

Meera gave her a tight-lipped smile begging herself to believe it. That was the end of the session. She rose from her seat, waved goodbye and left.

Angelique sat back in her chair, eyes closed.

The candle flickered once—though there was no breeze.

And somewhere, just beyond the veil of perception, a low murmur pulsed in the quiet:

A soft masculine laugh. The kind that made her heart ache. She didn’t open her eyes. Just let a tear roll down her cheek. Then she whispered,

“She heard you, you know... in the silence between her sobs.”

Four

The Man Who Saw Too Much



The rain hadn't arrived yet, but the sky was already rehearsing for it—clouds sagging like tired lungs, winds whispering promises they may or may not keep. Angelique lit a single cedar wood incense and cracked her window open. The scent curled into the air like a secret.

The chair across from her was still empty, but she could already feel his presence. Some clients had that effect. Like their energy arrived ten minutes before they did.

Then—soft footfalls. The door opened, and Nirav stepped in.

He looked better. Not perfect. But better.

The curls on his head were no longer matted. His camera bag was slung neatly across his shoulder instead of being clutched like a life raft. His eyes still held galaxies, yes—but now they weren't collapsing into themselves.

Angelique offered a smile. "You found your way back."

The Man Who Saw Too Much

He smiled faintly, settling into the couch like someone reacquainting themselves with gravity. "I figured it was time I stopped pretending I was fine."

"Good," she said gently. "Pretending is exhausting."

For a while, they didn't speak. She let the silence breathe, like she always did. Nirav didn't fidget this time. Just stared out the window at the grey-tinged sky.

Then finally, he spoke.

"I had another one of those dreams last night."

Angelique's eyes softened. "The girl again?"

He nodded. "This time she was standing on a bridge... barefoot. She had ink all over her arms—words, scribbles, little broken phrases. She kept looking down at the water like it had something she wanted to remember."

He paused. "Then she turned around and said to me, 'Tell her I don't want to jump. I just want to stop floating.'"

A silence bloomed. A sacred kind.

Angelique leaned forward slightly. "What did you feel when she said that?"

"Like my chest cracked open. Like it wasn't just a dream." He looked down. "She felt real. I could smell her perfume."

"She is," Angelique said simply, and let that truth land without explanation.

Nirav blinked. "You believe me?"

"I believe the soul remembers in strange ways."

There was no fear in her voice. No clinical distance. Just the kind of grounded knowing that made Nirav feel, for the first time in a long time, like he wasn't broken—just decoding something no one else had learned to read yet.

He exhaled shakily. "Do you think it means something?"

"I think it always means something," she said. "Especially

when it refuses to leave.”

Nirav closed his eyes, the image of the girl still playing behind his eyelids. “I want to know what she needs from me.”

Angelique gave him a knowing look. “Maybe it’s not about her needing something. Maybe it’s about what she’s showing you... about yourself.”

He let that sit with him. You could almost hear the cogs in his psyche adjusting.

Outside, thunder rumbled like a warning. Inside, Nirav reached for his water bottle and took a slow sip, grounding himself.

In that moment, Angelique thought back to the day that he had stumbled into her office for the first time...

* * *

The walls had felt too close that day. As if the room itself were breathing.

Nirav had walked in with his camera slung across his chest like armor. He didn’t make eye contact. Didn’t sit. Just stood near the door, one hand gripping the strap, the other twitching near his jacket zipper.

Angelique didn’t rush. She watched the tremble in his fingers, the way his eyes darted toward the windows as if something was perched outside watching.

“You don’t have to talk,” she said gently. “But you can, if it feels safe.”

He stayed quiet for another full minute. Then:

“I can’t trust the light anymore.”

Angelique tilted her head. “Tell me why.”

He finally sat—on the very edge of the couch, like he might

The Man Who Saw Too Much

spring off it if it said the wrong thing.

"They change when I look away. Shadows. Corners. They whisper. I know it sounds crazy. But they say things that sound like me."

Angelique didn't flinch. "You hear your own voice?"

He nodded. "Sometimes it's mean. Sometimes it's scared. Sometimes... I don't know if it's me at all."

She noted his disorganized speech patterns—looped phrases, sudden tangents, a fracturing of thoughts that skipped from photography to God to a bird that once died on his windowsill.

His words were beautiful, in a painful kind of way. Like poetry unraveling at the seams.

"They say I'm too open," he muttered. "Like my head doesn't have walls anymore. Like... I see too much. I feel things that aren't mine."

Angelique watched his pupils—they weren't dilated, but they held that glassy far-off shimmer she had learned to recognize. The kind of look that belongs to people who live half-in, half-out of the world.

"Do you ever feel like your thoughts aren't your own?" she asked carefully.

His answer was instant. "All the time."

She nodded, grounding her energy. "That sounds exhausting."

His voice cracked. "I don't want meds. I don't want to be one of *those* people who sleepwalk through life."

Angelique didn't argue. She never started with the big conversations. Not when someone still believed they had to fight to stay real.

"Do you remember when it started?" she asked softly.

His hands twitched again. "Two years ago. After the

exhibition. I hadn't slept in days. I thought it was just stress. But then... I saw her."

Angelique's breath caught, just a little.

"Her?"

He nodded. "A girl. Standing in the middle of my hallway. She looked... broken. Beautiful. She didn't say anything. Just cried. But her eyes were filled with oceans I couldn't name."

He shook his head slowly, like trying to reset a dream.

"She comes back sometimes. In my sleep. Always crying. But sometimes... sometimes she looks at me like she knows I can't help her."

Angelique's fingers twitched slightly in her lap. This wasn't the first time a client had seen someone from another chapter of life. She'd learned to listen closely when the veil thinned like this.

She didn't ask for more details then. The story was still growing inside him. But she made a note.

A girl made of oceans. A soul soaked in sorrow. Remember her.

* * *

The present version of Nirav sat cross-legged, a quiet testament to how far he'd come. The tremor in his hand was barely there now. His eyes, though still rimmed with weariness, held a softness. The kind that arrives when someone has survived their own mind, again and again.

Angelique studied him gently. There was no chaos in his presence today. Just stillness. Earned. Fragile. Beautiful.

"Last night was strange," Nirav said, fingers tracing the worn strap of his camera. "I had a dream. Or a vision. Not sure what to call it anymore."

The Man Who Saw Too Much

She didn't interrupt. She rarely did.

"I was in a field... everything was lavender. The air, the sky... even the birds. Too quiet. Then I saw her again."

Angelique's fingers stilled.

"The girl?"

He nodded. "The one from the first episode. She wasn't crying this time. Just... kneeling by a stream, whispering to the water."

"And what did she say?"

"She looked up," he said, "not at me — *through* me. Like I was just glass. And she whispered, 'Tell her I'm sorry I couldn't stay.' And then she was gone."

A silence fell. Angelique felt the now-familiar pull in her chest — the one that whispered *remember this*. She reached for her onyx pendant, thumb brushing over it like a compass finding north.

"She's become more gentle in your visions," she said. "That usually means you've stopped running from what she symbolizes."

Nirav nodded slowly, his voice lower now. "I think I stopped being afraid when I started understanding myself."

Angelique leaned back, watching him with something akin to pride.

"I take the meds on time now," he continued, almost like a confession. "Olanzapine. Lower dose. I resisted it at first... but now I see the difference. The static's not gone, but it's... muted."

She smiled. "That's a big win, Nirav."

"I also use that 5-4-3-2-1 grounding exercise when I feel the unreality creeping in. And cold water on the wrists. And journaling — when I can focus. I try to talk to people now, even if it feels like shouting underwater some days."

21 Mirrors

Angelique felt a surge of warmth bloom in her chest. This was the part most people never saw. The slow, courageous choreography of recovery.

"Sometimes," he added quietly, "I still have that fear. That I'll slip again. That reality will blur, and I won't know what's real anymore."

"And then?" she asked.

"I call my mom," he said. "I hated her for a long time, you know? When I was a kid... she used to lock herself in the bathroom when she got overwhelmed. I'd sit outside the door and count tiles on the floor. That's how I learned to dissociate. And to count."

Angelique stayed silent. Letting the weight of that memory settle.

"She doesn't lock doors anymore. We talk. Not about the past... but about recipes. The weather. Her back pain. But it helps."

Angelique smiled gently. "Sometimes healing is just learning how to stay in the same room with someone who once made you want to leave."

He looked up — startled, then softened.

"I think I'm ready to photograph people again," he said. "Not for work. Just... to remember faces. Capture moments. Maybe if I see others clearly enough, I'll keep seeing myself."

She reached into a small bowl on the table and picked out a polished obsidian stone. Not magic. Just memory, solidified. "For grounding," she said. "Carry it. Let it remind you that you've already walked through the fog — and lived."

Nirav took it with reverence.

As he rose to leave, Angelique caught sight of something odd — a white, speckled feather nestled on the floor near

The Man Who Saw Too Much

the window. No wind. No bird in sight. Still, it pulsed with meaning.

She picked it up after he left, placed it gently in her drawer next to her journal, and scribbled down a single line:

“She will return. Not through him — but through her own storm.” A sudden flash of a star shining brightly in the night sky popped into her head like a download.

That girl would find her way back. Not through Nirav’s mind, but through her own pain, her own fire, her own unraveling.

Angelique didn’t know her yet.

But the universe had already whispered her name.

Five

The Girl Who Stayed Too Long



It was the heels first.

Click-clack. Click-clack.

Not the hesitant shuffle of most clients—Sana strode in like the room owed her money.

Angelique didn't look up right away. She never did. She listened instead—to the energy, to the sound of purpose disguised as confidence.

Sana tossed her oversized tote bag on the sofa like it had offended her.

"Yo," she said, flashing a quick smile that didn't touch her eyes. "Sorry I'm late. Hungover from hell. Also...kind of ghosted someone last night. I think I'm becoming the villain."

Angelique raised her gaze with a soft smile. "That's alright. Welcome back, Sana."

Sana sat, crossed her legs like a magazine ad, then immediately slumped like the pose had betrayed her.

The Girl Who Stayed Too Long

"No soy la princesa anymore," she sighed. "Anyway... let's get this over with."

Angelique tilted her head. "Anything in particular you'd like to talk about today?"

A beat.

Then Sana pulled her shades off slowly. Her eyeliner was still perfect. Her pupils were not.

"Remember that guy I mentioned last week? The one I wasn't *really* seeing?" Her fingers made air quotes. "Yeah, turns out he was never *really* mine to begin with."

She let out a low laugh. "What do the kids say these days? Lemme cook? Well, I cooked. I served. He tasted. He left."

Angelique nodded slowly, letting the rhythm settle.

"And how does that feel, being left?"

Sana smirked. "Expected. But like... insultingly expected, y'know? I saw the red flags. I just thought I'd be the exception. Isn't that always the tragedy?"

Angelique's eyes softened. "Tell me more about what you thought you were the exception *to*."

Sana paused. Her jaw clenched almost imperceptibly.

"I guess I thought if I stayed chill enough, hot enough, detached enough... he'd want to stay. But turns out, I was just auditioning for a role in a movie that had no script."

She looked around, as if suddenly noticing the room again. The lavender candle. The faint hum of wind chimes from the open window.

"I've had actual relationships that hurt less than this almost-thing," she said. "Like—how the hell does that make sense?"

Angelique leaned forward just slightly. "Because sometimes, the *almosts* leave deeper wounds than the *nevers*. There's grief in unfinished business."

21 Mirrors

The sentence landed hard.

Sana blinked rapidly. The space between her boldness and her breaking heart was closing in fast.

"I don't even know why it hurts this much," she said. "It's not like he *used* me. We were just... vibing. Drinking. Hooking up. Talking deep at 2 a.m. It was fun. Casual. Whatever. Right?"

Silence.

Angelique didn't rush to fill it.

Sana looked down at her rings, twisting one slowly.

"I think I was just grateful someone saw me. Even if it was only through the lens of his convenience."

And just like that, the real session had begun.

* * *

Angelique let the silence breathe again. She was starting to realize Sana never truly paused unless someone else did first.

"It's weird, you know?" Sana finally said, her voice quieter now. "I used to think I was the heartbreaker. The emotionally unavailable one. But suddenly I'm crying into my pillow over a guy who didn't even remember my birthday."

She laughed—sharp and hollow.

Angelique leaned back, hands resting lightly on the arms of her chair. "Maybe the roles we play aren't fixed. Maybe we've just been rehearsing survival for so long, we forgot to rewrite the script."

Sana looked up at her, mascara daring not to run.

"Don't do that therapist-mystic mashup on me. I'll cry for real."

Angelique didn't blink. "Maybe you need to."

Sana broke.

The Girl Who Stayed Too Long

Not loudly. Not with sobs. But with the softest betrayal: a single tear slipping past all that carefully layered defiance.

"I stayed too long," she whispered. "In something that didn't even exist."

Angelique leaned forward now, elbows on knees, gaze gentle but unflinching.

"That's the thing about almost-love," she said. "It doesn't end with closure. It ends with questions."

She reached for the small sand timer on her desk—flipped it once. "Do you want to try something?"

Sana sniffled, then nodded slowly. "Hit me."

"Close your eyes," Angelique said softly. "I want you to picture the version of you who was in love with him. The one who stayed up waiting for replies. Who read too much into emojis. Who edited texts before sending. Who performed chill while internally combusting."

Sana closed her eyes.

Angelique continued, voice steady. "Now imagine her standing in front of you. What do you want to say to her?"

Sana's voice cracked. "I'm sorry I abandoned you just to feel chosen."

Angelique inhaled slowly, letting the ache settle in the room.

"Now imagine her walking away. Not because she's being left. But because she's finally choosing herself."

Sana opened her eyes, a glint of something raw and clean breaking through.

"You're good," she said. "Like scary-good."

Angelique smiled faintly. "I just remind people of what they already know."

There was a flicker in the air—like a temperature drop that wasn't real.

21 *Mirrors*

Sana glanced sideways. “This room always feels... different. Like something else is here.”

Angelique didn’t answer that. Not with words.

She only looked over at the antique mirror hanging behind the sofa. For just a second, it shimmered faintly.

* * *

Sana had gone quiet. The kind of quiet that wasn’t peace—it was pause. Angelique had learned to spot the difference.

“Tell me something,” Angelique said, gently rotating the malachite ring on her finger, “who was the first person that made you feel like love was something you had to earn?”

Sana blinked. “Damn, that’s a loaded question.”

Angelique just smiled.

Sana exhaled. “My dad, I guess. Or maybe my mom. I don’t know. My dad left when I was 8. My mom stayed, but... only physically. Emotionally? She was like a locked cabinet.”

There it was—the first thread. Angelique felt it settle into the room.

“She always made me feel like I was asking for too much,” Sana continued. “If I cried—‘Don’t be dramatic.’ If I wanted her attention—‘I’m busy.’ I learned how to stop needing. It made her easier to love.”

Angelique let the silence breathe again, then asked, “Do you think that’s what you’re doing in relationships now?”

Sana gave a weak laugh. “I mean... yeah. I shrink, I adapt, I try not to take up space. And when I do take space, I apologize for it like I just broke something sacred.”

The words fell out of her like water from a glass too full.

“That’s a heavy pattern to carry alone,” Angelique said softly.

The Girl Who Stayed Too Long

“That’s not love. That’s survival.”

Sana looked away. Her fingers trembled a little, tugging at the hem of her sleeve. “Sometimes I wonder if I even know what love is. Or if I just chase versions of my mother in every man I date.”

Angelique stood and walked to the sideboard where her antique mirror stood, catching a glint of light. She didn’t look into it—she never did. She just brushed her fingers along the edge. The glass seemed to hum faintly.

“Sana,” she said, returning to her chair, “You never needed to become smaller to be held. But I think somewhere along the line, your nervous system was taught that safety meant silence. That stillness meant survival.”

Sana’s eyes welled up. “It’s like... I’m dating ghosts, you know? No one’s ever fully here. Or maybe I’m not. Maybe I’ve never been all the way present in love either.”

Angelique nodded, almost reverently. “Because if you showed up fully, and they left, it would confirm the fear: that you are too much. That your presence is what drives them away.”

Sana pressed her palms to her face and cried. Not the loud kind. The kind where the soul does most of the breaking.

Angelique kneeled beside her again and placed a hand on her knee. “You don’t need to be fixed. You just need to be witnessed. Fully. Without conditions.”

After a while, when the tears had slowed, Angelique handed her a small card from the drawer. On it, a simple task.

Homework: Write down all the times you were made to feel like you were “too much.”

One sentence each. No editing.

Then next to each line, write what you actually needed in

21 Mirrors

that moment.

Start retraining the story.

Sana took it like it was more than a piece of paper. Maybe a key.

As she walked out of the office, her gaze caught the mirror's surface—and for a second, her reflection lingered just a second too long. Her eyes looked like they belonged to a little girl, standing at the edge of a door that had always stayed closed.

Angelique didn't move.

She whispered beneath her breath, almost inaudibly—

"Some people don't need closure.

They just need to finally choose themselves."

Six

The Boy Who Became Himself



The rain had been falling for hours.

Not the stormy, passionate kind. The slow, unapologetic drizzle that soaks through everything you are if you stand in it too long.

Angelique glanced at the clock. Her 3:30 was running five minutes late. She didn't mind. He always took a moment before walking in. Some people needed a beat outside to remember who they were.

A soft knock.

"Come in."

The door creaked, and in walked a tall, lean young man with a softness about him that seemed to defy every rigid expectation the world had ever pressed into his bones. His features were delicate—chin clean-shaven, posture still learning confidence—but his eyes... his eyes had always held truth.

"Hi," he said. "Sorry I'm late. The cab guy kept calling me *sir*

21 Mirrors

and I didn't correct him. I think that slowed me down more than traffic."

Angelique smiled gently. "You're here. That's enough."

He exhaled, and with it came a tiny, invisible storm. Of words never said. Of selves never allowed.

She watched him settle into the couch, long legs crossed nervously, fingers fidgeting with the sleeves of his black hoodie.

"I've been binding more often lately," he said. "Even when I'm home. Is that... bad?"

Angelique tilted her head. "Do you feel safe when you do it?"

"Yes," he whispered.

"Then it's not bad. It's a form of holding yourself until the world catches up."

His eyes flickered. "I like that."

* * *

His name was Rey. Assigned female at birth, now 22, and halfway through his medical transition. It had taken him three years to even say the word "trans" out loud in this room. Another six months to stop apologizing for taking up space.

"I saw my dad again," he said quietly. "He still uses my old name. It's not even aggressive anymore. It's just... indifference. Like I'm a blurry photo he refuses to reprint."

Angelique winced, not outwardly, but somewhere deep behind the heart chakra.

"Indifference can hurt worse than anger," she said. "Anger at least implies energy. Indifference feels like erasure."

Rey blinked rapidly.

"I thought after top surgery I'd feel better. And I do, sometimes. But other times I look in the mirror and I still

The Boy Who Became Himself

feel... trapped. Like this body is only halfway home.”

She nodded. “That’s because dysphoria isn’t always about form. It’s also about memory. Your body isn’t just yours—it’s everyone else’s version of you too.”

His shoulders slumped. “I just want to exist without explaining myself.”

“You will,” Angelique said softly. “But some days, you’ll have to explain to *yourself* too. And that’s okay.”

* * *

The lavender incense was still burning when he said it:

“Sometimes I still hear her voice—my mother’s. When I used to wear skirts as a kid and she’d say, ‘You’re my pretty little girl. Don’t ruin that.’ I hear it when I shop for shirts now. I hear it when I try to speak deeper.”

Angelique moved closer but didn’t interrupt.

“It’s like her voice is a ghost I’m still trying to exorcise from my throat.”

Angelique reached into the drawer beside her and pulled out a small piece of obsidian—the grounding stone.

“This is for memory,” she said. “Not to forget. But to remind you that you’ve survived every version of yourself so far.”

Rey took it with reverence.

There was a pause, thick and sacred. The kind that lives in church pews and prayer rooms.

“I had a dream last week,” he said. “I was running through a field at sunset. And someone—me, but not me—kept calling out a name I didn’t recognize.”

“What name?”

He hesitated. “Ash.”

21 *Mirrors*

Angelique's eyes flickered.

"That was you," she said. "A past version. Or maybe a future one. But definitely... you."

Rey smiled for the first time that day. "I liked that name."

"Maybe write to him," Angelique offered. "Let him know you're on your way."

* * *

As he got up to leave, Rey lingered by the door.

"You think I'll ever feel whole?" he asked.

Angelique didn't respond right away.

Instead, she stood, walked over to the antique mirror hanging across the room, and placed a hand gently against the surface.

The reflection shimmered—just faintly, like it sometimes did when energy cracked open.

"I don't think you'll feel whole," she said finally. "I think you already are. You're just unwrapping it. One layer at a time."

Rey stood silently for a moment. Then nodded, almost as if something clicked.

Before he left, Angelique handed him a soft-bound journal with a hand-inked symbol on the cover.

"Your only task this week," she said, "is to write a letter to the name that came to you in your dream. Imagine they've been waiting to hear from you. Write like your life depends on it."

He clutched the notebook, fingers brushing over the cover like it might hum back.

"What if I don't know what to say?"

Angelique smiled.

"Start with hello."

And as the door clicked shut behind him, Angelique whis-

The Boy Who Became Himself

pered toward the mirror:

"Welcome home, Ash."

Seven

The Girl Who Was Different



This had started about a month ago.

It was late evening when Ira had called. Not a scheduled catch-up—just one of those soft, unspoken SOS calls between women who’ve weathered too many storms together.

Angelique was folding away the last of her laundry when her phone buzzed. She answered without checking the screen.

“Hey,” Ira’s voice came, steady but too polite. That kind of polite that meant she was trying to stay composed.

“Ira?” Angelique asked, already sensing the pause that followed wasn’t about lost signal.

“I need a favor,” Ira said.

Angelique stopped folding.

“It’s my daughter, Mira. She’s three. She’s... different. Smart, but... not talking yet. Not really looking at people. The pediatrician said ‘developmental delay’ but I’ve seen the signs. You know I’ve seen them.”

The Girl Who Was Different

Angelique leaned against the wall, eyes closed. She'd known Ira since college. Ira didn't panic easily.

"I don't want to wait around and watch the world fail her because we didn't act in time. You used to work with kids, right? In that center?" Ira's voice cracked a little. "Can you take a look? Not officially. Just... as a favor?"

Angelique thought of the polished grey floors of the center she'd worked in years ago. Of cue cards and PECs charts and the sound of timers ticking between tasks. She'd left that world behind to walk into deeper ones—more intuitive, more spiritual. But roots like that don't leave you. ABA never really leaves you.

"Alright," she said softly. "Bring her in next week."

"Really?" Ira asked, voice almost lifting with hope.

Angelique smiled faintly. "Of course. For Mira... and for you."

As she hung up, she felt something stir in her chest. Not dread. Not burden. A sense of... remembering. Like an old tool in her hand still fit perfectly.

* * *

Back to the present, Angelique had deliberately chosen a room without too many bright colors or jarring textures. The light green rug in the middle of the floor was soft and simple—a quiet invitation rather than a command. In one corner, shelves held basic toys sorted in clear bins: blocks, animals, a bubble wand.

Mira sat near the rug, her small fingers rotating the wheels of a toy car without ever pushing it forward. Her eyes flicked sideways occasionally brief glances that never fully settled on

anything but the object in her hand.

Ira sat on a small chair close by, clearly trying not to hover. Her knees were clasped, her eyes watching every micro-expression on her daughter's face like they were clues in a mystery novel.

Angelique sat cross-legged at a gentle distance, not too close, not too far. This wasn't their first session together—Angelique had been building a gentle scaffolding over the past few weeks: pairing herself with preferred activities, slowly increasing proximity, offering consistent reinforcement.

"Hi Mira," she said softly.

Mira didn't respond immediately, but there was a subtle pause in her repetitive motion.

Angelique smiled. "I see you're playing with the blue car today."

She reached into a nearby bin and pulled out a red car, rolling it on the floor gently. "Vroooooom," she said in a melodic voice.

Out of the corner of her eye, she caught a flicker of interest. No eye contact yet, but Mira's hand paused, her fingers curling slightly.

"That's nice," Angelique said warmly. She looked at Ira. "That's engagement."

Ira exhaled like she'd been holding her breath.

"We've made good progress since last week," Angelique said, tone reassuring. "Her name response has improved. Still intermittent, but we're getting more consistent reactions when her name is paired with a preferred item."

Angelique tapped a small laminated card beside her, one of Mira's favorites—a visual of bubbles.

"Watch this," she said, holding up the bubble wand. "Mira?"

No response. Angelique waited three seconds, then tried

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again. “Mira,” she said gently, pairing the name with the visual and pausing once more.

On the third cue, Mira turned slightly toward the wand—just enough to register intent. Her lips parted, and a faint vocalization escaped.

Angelique lit up. “Yes! Good looking, Mira!”

She blew a stream of bubbles into the air and Mira followed them with her eyes, her small body leaning just slightly toward the shimmer.

“I can’t tell you how big that is,” Ira whispered, her voice thick.

Angelique nodded. “Joint attention. Still emerging, but she’s reaching for it. She’s starting to connect the dots that people bring joy too—not just objects.”

As Mira returned to her car, Angelique looked at Ira with a kind but serious expression.

“We may want to explore Oral Placement Therapy soon. Some of her pre-linguistic oral motor patterns are still underdeveloped. It’s not speech therapy exactly—it’s more like prepping the mouth to be speech-ready.”

Ira looked overwhelmed but nodded. “Whatever helps.”

“She’s very sensory-seeking in some ways,” Angelique added. “But also avoids certain textures. It’s a unique profile—but not uncommon. We’ll continue pairing ourselves with her sensory world before we try to shift it.”

Angelique stood and walked over to Mira, kneeling slowly beside her, not breaking the rhythm of their work.

“Mira,” she said again, holding up a small puzzle board with a familiar animal.

“Can you show me the duck?”

Mira didn’t respond—but her hand moved toward the

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correct piece. She didn't place it, but she held it. A beginning.

Angelique met her where she was. "Good holding!" she said gently, tapping her own chin to model a point of reference. "Duck."

Mira didn't echo it, but her gaze stayed a fraction longer than it had last week.

Progress. Always in millimeters. But it added up.

* * *

Mira was now seated by the window, entranced by the way sunlight filtered through the bubble wand Angelique had left on the sill. She turned it in her small hands like it was a magic artifact—seeing light, not color.

Angelique walked Ira out quietly, the door clicking gently behind them.

"She had a good day," Ira said, wiping her palms on her jeans. "I think it's the first time I've seen her pause when someone called her name."

"You're showing up for her, Ira. That's the real miracle."

Ira's lips trembled at the corners. "It's just hard. My friends are planning birthday parties and playdates... I'm trying to figure out if she even knows I'm her mom."

Angelique placed a hand on her shoulder. "She knows. Just not in the way you're used to being known."

There was silence for a beat. Then Ira whispered, "Is it always going to be this hard?"

Angelique didn't give false comfort. "It's always going to require intention. But it won't always feel like drowning."

Ira smiled, watery-eyed. "Thank you."

Once Ira had left, Angelique turned back toward the room.

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Mira was still by the window, now holding the duck puzzle piece like it was a puzzle of her own making.

Angelique didn't approach. Instead, she sat in her chair, hands folded, and just watched.

Across the room, the antique mirror—the one with edges worn smooth by time—reflected the girl bathed in sunbeam and silence.

Angelique's gaze dropped to her lap. She pulled out her small leather-bound notebook and scribbled:

Name response improving. Possible early symbolic play. Auditory processing still minimal. Consider weighted lap pad for next session. Ask Ira to record home routines.

And then, lower down in the margin:

She looked at the duck. Not with confusion. But with wonder.

She smiled faintly and touched the onyx pendant at her throat.

Angelique always carried a certain stillness in her bones. The kind of stillness that children—especially sensitive ones—recognized. That's what Angelique had always believed: neurodivergent children weren't unreachable. They just required a language older than speech.

As she sat there, the wind rustled outside, and a faint knock echoed—not from the door, but the mirror's edge. A flutter. A shimmer. Nothing loud enough to disturb.

Just enough for Angelique to whisper, "I know. She's coming back."

* * *

Later that night, Angelique sat cross-legged on the floor of her apartment, soft Sufi music playing in the background. Dobby

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the cat had curled into a comma-shaped crescent near her foot. The room smelled faintly of vetiver and eucalyptus.

She opened her session journal—not the clinical one, but the one that lived in her private drawer. The one where notes became insights, and insights became prayers.

She wrote:

Mira: 3 years, female. Nonverbal. Speech delay. Sensory-seeking. Strong visual attention emerging. Eye contact improving with cues. Still struggling with transitions. Responded to bubble play and matching tasks. OT and OPT consult needed soon.

Then, under a different heading, one she reserved only for herself:

Reflections:

Sometimes I wonder if children like Mira aren't here to be "fixed" at all.

Maybe they're just reminders—living breathing pauses in a world that never stops.

Maybe their souls chose silence to remind ours how to listen.

Maybe they see dimensions we've long forgotten to believe in.

She doesn't speak. But she *hears*. In a way the world doesn't have vocabulary for yet.

Angelique set the journal aside and opened her phone to text Ira:

Homework this week

- * Continue name response work during play (not when giving instructions)

- * Introduce two simple visual schedules for daily routines—morning & bedtime

- * Keep a log of what calms her down vs what overwhelms her

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* And one more thing: watch for joy. Track it. It's her language.

She paused, added a final note:

"Let's also try humming together next time. Sometimes music speaks where words can't."

She turned off the light, but the mirror in her living room caught a sliver of moonlight. For just a second, it looked like the silhouette of a child was dancing in it—spinning slowly in the glow, holding a puzzle piece.

Angelique didn't flinch. Just closed her eyes and whispered:

"You're not broken, little one. You're just remembering differently."

Eight

The Girl Who Loved Too Hard



Angelique had lit the sandalwood incense just moments before the knock came—three soft, uncertain taps. Something in her chest flickered. Not pain. Not dread. Recognition.

She opened the door to a girl with paint on her fingertips and sleep-deprived poetry in her eyes. Her curls were tangled, like she hadn't brushed them in days—or maybe she had and simply given up halfway. She looked like someone who dreamed too much and slept too little.

"Come in," Angelique said gently, already aware this one would leave footprints behind.

The girl stepped inside slowly, scanning the room not with judgment, but with the kind of raw hyper awareness that comes from having been deeply misunderstood. Her aura shimmered and stung, like a sunburn beneath layers of charm.

"I'm Tara," she said, half a whisper, like she wasn't entirely convinced she should exist.

The Girl Who Loved Too Hard

The flash of a star in the night sky popped back into Angelique's head.

She nodded. "You're safe here."

Tara sank onto the couch and curled one leg underneath herself, then instantly uncrossed it. The restlessness came off her like static.

"I didn't know who else to call," she said, voice brittle. "I've been... seeing things. Not hallucinations or anything. Just... flashes. Last night I dreamt of a man. A man with tired eyes. He said I shouldn't jump. That you'd help me." Her throat bobbed. "I live alone. I was standing on the balcony when I woke up."

Angelique froze.

The man. The vision. Nirav's voice echoing in her memory:

She had red ink on her hands. Not blood. Ink. Like she had been trying to write something all night and couldn't get the words right. And she was standing on a ledge. And I wasn't sure if she could hear me...

A slow chill ran down her spine.

Tara pulled her sleeves over her hands. "I think I'm going mad."

Angelique sat down across from her, heart steady even as her breath caught. "You're not mad. But your heart's carrying more than it knows how to hold."

Tara's lip quivered, and for a second, she looked like a child who'd been scolded too often and loved too little.

She whispered, "Sometimes I don't know if I want to die... or if I just don't want to keep surviving like this."

Angelique's voice lowered like a prayer:

"You're not broken. You're burning. There's a difference."

Tara didn't cry.

She spoke with the calm cadence of someone who had practiced masking every jagged edge until it became performance art.

"I don't even know what I'm doing anymore," she said. "I paint for days without sleeping. And then crash. I go from writing music like a prophet to lying in bed for hours, staring at the ceiling, wondering if anyone would notice if I disappeared."

Her hands were wrapped around a chipped ceramic mug Angelique had handed her—chamomile, sweetened just enough to trick the nervous system into trust.

"Does it feel like your mind shifts into different worlds?" Angelique asked softly, watching the way Tara's eyes darted before she nodded.

"Yeah," she said. "It's like there are two of me. One who feels *everything* and wants to cling, and another who's so scared of being left that she pushes people away before they can even try."

Angelique's tone was warm, clinical, human. "That sounds like emotional dysregulation. What you're describing—these intense mood shifts, identity confusion, unstable relationships—it sounds like Borderline Personality traits."

Tara flinched—not from fear, but recognition. "I've read about that. People say we're manipulative... dangerous."

Angelique leaned in, eyes steady. "People who say that don't understand. BPD is not a moral failing—it's a survival strategy. It's a map drawn from trauma."

Tara nodded, too quickly. "I *feel* things before I understand them. And when I fall for someone, I fall like it's the last air I'll

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ever breathe.”

Angelique wrote silently for a moment. Then, as if remembering something personal, she looked up.

“Tell me about your *favorite* person.”

Tara hesitated. “His name’s Ahaan. We were... something. Not quite a relationship. But more than friends. He said he cared. Then disappeared for days. And I lost it. I called, texted, even went to his place.”

Her voice caught. “I hated that version of me.”

Angelique didn’t flinch. “That version of you was terrified of abandonment. That’s not hateworthy. That’s human.”

Tara’s fingers trembled slightly around the mug. “It’s like I become this... glass heart. Always cracking, always clinging.”

Angelique said, “That’s the emotional splitting. The black-and-white thinking. You either feel like someone is your everything—or they’re nothing. And both states feel real.”

“And I *know* it’s irrational,” Tara groaned. “But when I’m in it... it’s like I can’t stop the storm.”

Angelique gave a gentle smile. “The storm isn’t you. It’s the wound reacting to the weather.”

Silence sat between them for a while—soft, reverent.

Tara finally asked, “Do you think I can heal?”

“I think you already are,” Angelique said. “You’re sitting here. You reached out. That’s not weakness. That’s strength with scars.”

A single tear slipped from Tara’s left eye, tracing the slope of a cheek that had been kissed too little by comfort.

Angelique let it fall.

* * *

Tara was talking faster now. Not manic—just unfiltered.

“When I split... I become this other person. I start calling Ahaan toxic. Say I don’t care if he vanishes. I block him, I scream into my pillow, I write angry poems about him. And then... the next day, I miss him like he was air.”

Angelique didn’t interrupt. She knew that this wasn’t contradiction—it was a cry for coherence.

Splitting wasn’t deception. It was survival. It was the nervous system flipping through channels to escape an emotional fire.

She waited for the storm to pass.

“You’re not alone in that,” she said softly. “Splitting isn’t about hate. It’s about fear. You’re protecting yourself from feeling the burn of being abandoned again.”

Tara looked down, shame coloring her cheeks. “I talk shit about him to everyone. Even though I don’t mean half of it.”

Angelique nodded. “That’s the holy rage. The part of you that lashes out to prove you don’t need them—because the part of you that *does* need them is terrified.”

Then she reached for the small glass tray beside her—where she kept therapy tools like flashcards and scribbled worksheets she’d made herself over the years.

Angelique handed Tara a folded paper.

A weekly *splitting map*.

“Each time you feel yourself flipping from ‘he’s everything’ to ‘he’s the worst,’ fill this in:

1. **Trigger:** What happened just before the split?
2. **Emotion:** What were you feeling in your body?
3. **Belief:** What did your mind say? (‘He’s using me,’ ‘I’m unlovable’)
4. **Old wound:** Does this mirror something from child-

hood?

5. **Alternative story:** What else *could* be true?

Tara blinked, looking at it like it was a lifeline.

“It’s not about stopping the split,” Angelique said gently. “It’s about *not believing it completely*. That’s how Dialectical Behavior Therapy works. You don’t fight the emotion—you ride it with awareness.”

Tara nodded slowly.

“I also want you to start journaling using *mentalization-based therapy* style prompts,” Angelique continued. “Ask yourself: ‘What was I feeling? What might they have been feeling?’ It’s about seeing the other person as *real*—not just a threat or savior.”

“And TFP?” Tara asked, surprising Angelique with her knowledge.

She smiled. “We’ll explore that in future sessions. But just know—it’s okay to love and hate someone at the same time. The goal isn’t purity. It’s wholeness.”

For the first time that hour, Tara looked... peaceful. Like a battle had eased up.

Angelique lit a small black candle on the shelf behind her—a ritual she sometimes performed when she sensed emotional ghosts beginning to quiet.

“I feel like I’m too much for this world,” Tara whispered.

Angelique tilted her head, eyes calm.

“No, love. The world has simply grown too full of NPCs. People who are numbed out, sedated, flattened by screens and sameness. You’re not *too much*. You’re just still *alive* in a world pretending not to feel.”

Tara let the words sink in.

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And when she stepped outside minutes later, into the gold rush of 5:30 sun, the wind caught her hair just slightly.

Like something unseen had whispered:

Stay. You're meant to feel.

Nine

The Woman Who Was Never Enough



Somewhere between 3 a.m. and 4, Rhea decided she was a fraud.

Not the small kind — not the “forgot to cite a source” or “exaggerated my resume” kind. No, this was existential. Bone-deep. She stared at the glowing render on her screen — a hauntingly beautiful album cover stitched together from pixels, prompts, and Midjourney magic. Her name would go at the bottom. Signed like an artist. Except... she hadn’t *painted* it. Not exactly.

She closed her laptop like it had just confessed something unforgivable.

Now, thirteen hours later, she sat on a moss-green armchair, fidgeting with the cracked zipper of her tote bag, pretending not to notice how still the woman across from her was.

Angelique hadn’t spoken yet. She never rushed the beginning.

“So,” Rhea finally muttered, voice just above a whisper, “do people usually cry in the first session, or am I just winning at this already?”

Angelique’s eyes softened, amused. “Depends on the day. But there’s no leaderboard in therapy, I promise.”

Rhea let out a sharp exhale — not quite a laugh, not quite a sigh.

“I’m a graphic designer,” she said, tugging at her sleeves. “Freelance. Mostly branding, digital art, social media stuff. But lately... a lot of what I do is assisted by AI. I use Midjourney for base comps and finish the details myself.”

Angelique simply nodded.

“It’s been going *really* well, actually. Clients love it. But... I don’t know. Every time I get praise, I feel like I’m stealing something. Like I tricked them.”

“You feel like a fraud.”

“Exactly.” Rhea’s voice cracked slightly. “And it’s so confusing because I *do* work hard. I tweak the renders, build the concept, do the human part. But part of me thinks — if I didn’t type the right prompts, would this image even exist? Can I really call it mine?”

Angelique leaned back, letting the room breathe for them both.

“And what would happen,” she asked gently, “if someone you admired told you they did the same thing?”

Rhea hesitated. “I’d probably think... wow, smart move.”

“So why is it clever when someone else does it, but shameful when you do?”

Rhea blinked. The question clung to her like static.

Angelique waited. She didn’t fill silences. She allowed them to bloom.

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“Because I don’t feel like an artist anymore,” Rhea admitted. “I feel like a glorified curator.”

“Or maybe,” Angelique offered, “you’ve redefined what it means to create in an age where tools are evolving. And that makes you uncomfortable because no one taught you how to trust your own adaptability.”

Another silence — this one heavier. But not suffocating. More like a weighted blanket on a cold morning.

“Rhea,” Angelique said, her voice velvet now, “when did you first learn that your worth had to be proven?”

Rhea blinked, eyes suddenly hot. “When I was ten. I forged my mom’s signature on a drawing contest form. I won. But instead of being proud, she was furious I didn’t ask. She threw the drawing away.”

Angelique made a mental note: *Origin wound. Creativity + secrecy = guilt.*

“Since then,” Rhea continued, “I’ve always felt like I had to ‘earn’ being seen. Be impressive enough. Perfect enough. If I got something easily... it wasn’t valid.”

“And now,” Angelique said, “you’ve found a tool that lets things come easier. So your system’s panicking.”

Rhea nodded slowly, like something inside her had just realigned.

* * *

Rhea shifted in her seat, the kind of fidget that said *I want to be invisible but also understood*. Her fingers danced along the frayed edges of her sleeve like she was braiding her own anxiety into it.

“I have this... friend group,” she said slowly. “Design school

friends. They're doing these insane things now — getting featured in galleries, doing TEDx talks, some of them even got into these hyper-curated residencies abroad."

She paused, a bitter laugh caught in her throat. "I know Instagram is a highlight reel, but when you scroll through it every day... it feels like everyone else is sprinting while I'm stuck in molasses."

Angelique didn't interrupt. She was watching her client's language — not just what Rhea said, but how she said it. The metaphors of motion and stuckness. Sprinting. Molasses. Trapped in the very thing she once loved.

"Do you think they're better than you?" Angelique asked gently.

"No," Rhea said quickly. "I mean, yes. But no. Not *better*. Just... more deserving, maybe. More certain. They seem to own their space. I'm still... I don't know... sneaking around in mine."

Angelique leaned forward, her tone like warm earth. "You're not sneaking. You're surviving a world that gaslights creators into believing their value is based on how loud they are. You're allowed to move quietly."

Rhea's eyes welled up again — this time not from shame, but recognition. Someone had finally named it. *Quiet artistry in a noisy world*.

Angelique let the silence linger a moment longer before reaching for her notepad.

"I want you to try something," she said. "It's simple. But it's not easy."

Rhea looked up, eyes wary but curious.

"Each evening, I want you to write down three things you created or contributed to that day. Doesn't have to be design

The Woman Who Was Never Enough

work. It could be a mood board, an idea you journaled, even the way you styled your space or made breakfast with care.”

Rhea raised an eyebrow. “What’s the point?”

“To start untangling your worth from applause,” Angelique said. “You’re retraining your nervous system to witness your own creativity without waiting for someone to validate it.”

Rhea blinked. “So, like... self-recognition?”

“Exactly. Your nervous system has been hijacked by comparison. This exercise is about reestablishing a safe home inside your own creativity. One where you don’t need a badge to belong.”

That landed somewhere deep. Rhea nodded slowly, like someone who’d just been handed the keys to a room she didn’t know she was locked out of.

* * *

The session was almost over. A faint chime sounded from Angelique’s antique wall clock — soft enough to not startle, but firm enough to remind.

Rhea had sunk a little deeper into the couch by now, her body slightly more settled, like she’d released a few invisible bags she hadn’t realized she’d been carrying. Her palms no longer clenched her sleeves. Her voice, though still soft, held more substance.

Angelique watched with that quiet reverence she often reserved for clients who didn’t even realize they were healing mid-sentence.

“Sometimes,” Rhea whispered, “I feel like AI stole the part of me that made me special. I used to believe my work had

a fingerprint — like, something only I could make. But now there are apps that can replicate my style in seconds. What's the point of being a 'creative' if creativity isn't even rare anymore?"

Angelique exhaled slowly. She felt the truth of that. Not just as a therapist, but as a woman alive in a world that was digitizing soul.

She didn't rush to fix it.

Instead, she said, "Do you know the difference between a mirror and a window?"

Rhea looked confused, then shook her head.

"A mirror shows you yourself, but you're still trapped inside the frame. A window lets you see through — beyond you — into the world, into others, into new meaning. The goal isn't to make mirrors anymore. It's to become windows. That's what your art is meant to do."

Rhea's eyes widened. "But how do I know if I'm a window?"

"You'll know," Angelique said softly, "when someone tells you they saw something in your work that they didn't even know they needed."

Rhea let that sit. Her lips parted, but no words came. She simply nodded, slowly — as if agreeing not with Angelique, but with something ancient in herself that had just woken up.

Angelique stood up. The session was complete in all the ways that mattered. She walked over to the little tray by the window, poured Rhea a small glass of Tulsi and blue pea tea — her usual closing ritual for clients who felt emotionally raw. Something earthy. Something that reminded you your body was still here, still home.

As Rhea took the cup, she glanced around the room — at the shelves of old psychology books, the string lights framing a hanging dreamcatcher, and that mirror. The old one. The one

The Woman Who Was Never Enough

that felt like it remembered more than it should.

Her eyes landed on it for a heartbeat too long.

“Do you ever feel like this place is... alive?” she asked.

Angelique didn’t answer immediately.

Instead, she smiled.

And in that moment, Rhea swore — just for a flicker — that the mirror blinked.

Ten

The Boy Who Feared Everything



The first thing Angelique noticed about him was that he didn't want to be here.

Not in the usual hesitant way, either—no fidgeting, no uncertain glances. Just a thick wall of defensiveness, shoulders squared like armor, eyes scanning the room like it might try to psychoanalyze him without his permission.

He didn't sit down right away.

"Take your time," Angelique said, motioning toward the chair with the same calm grace she used when coaxing feral cats.

"My wife made me come," he announced, as though offering a disclaimer that would protect him from emotional liability.

Angelique smiled softly. "Well, that's honest. I appreciate that."

He sat, slowly. Crossed one leg over the other. Uncrossed. Crossed again.

He was around forty. Trim, weathered face, the kind that

The Boy Who Feared Everything

had known long commutes and quiet frustrations. A wedding band, a leather-strap watch, and a voice that sounded like it hadn't said anything tender in a while.

"I don't believe in therapy," he said.

"Okay," Angelique said. "But you believe in your wife."

That earned the smallest twitch of a smirk. "Yeah, she thinks I need to 'talk about things.' I'm not even sure what that means."

Angelique didn't flinch. Didn't dive into theory or technique. She just nodded, then leaned forward slightly.

"So... why does the ocean scare you?"

He blinked. No segue. No soft landing. Just a quiet, surgical cut to the heart of the thing.

He hesitated. Then, for the first time, looked her in the eye.

"I don't know," he said. "But I've never been able to get into water. Pools, lakes, showers if the pressure's too high—it's like my lungs forget what to do."

Angelique's eyes didn't widen, didn't judge. "How long has it been like that?"

"Always," he muttered. "Since I was a kid. I remember a school trip to a beach when I was nine. I didn't go in. Just sat there on the sand, pretending I was sick."

Angelique let the silence settle a little. "And recently?"

"I can't take my daughter to swimming class. I can't even watch her without feeling like I'm gonna throw up. That's what started the arguments at home. My wife said maybe I should talk to someone."

He gave a slight shrug, like it was all just an unfortunate plot twist in a movie he never meant to star in.

"Have you ever tried to understand where it came from?" she asked gently.

"I did this past life thing once," he said, like he was embar-

rassed. "Some regression therapy or whatever. The woman said I saw myself drowning in another life."

He rolled his eyes. "Felt like a damn movie. I mean, it freaked me out, but come on... I'm not into all that woo-woo stuff. I want real answers. Something that makes sense."

Angelique's lips curled into a quiet smile. "And what if both were real in their own way?"

He tilted his head. "What do you mean?"

"I mean, what if the memory was symbolic, not literal? A metaphor your nervous system painted with old paint. Trauma doesn't always speak in sentences. Sometimes it paints stories."

He didn't reply. But he wasn't resisting anymore either. Just sitting still. Listening.

Angelique took a small breath. This was the moment—the gentle crack where light could come in.

"Would you be willing," she asked, "to explore it with both your head and your gut? To let your body tell you the story, one layer at a time?"

He didn't nod. But he didn't say no.

Across the room, the onyx pendant at her throat caught a glint of morning sun, and Angelique knew: the real session was just beginning.

* * *

The monsoon had arrived early that year. Outside, the rain sketched long lines across the glass, tracing patterns like a language only the heart could read. Angelique lit a single white sandalwood incense stick as she waited, its smoke curling like breath from another realm.

At 11:02 a.m., he walked in—hesitant but earlier than last

The Boy Who Feared Everything

time. His movements weren't as guarded, but still carried a stiffness—as if he wasn't sure he deserved the seat.

"Morning," he said, sitting down without waiting for permission.

"Morning, Arman," Angelique replied, her tone light. "Thanks for being on time."

"I was already out. My wife said if I missed today, she'd drag me here herself."

Angelique smiled, jotting his name at the top of her session note. *Arman*. Late 40s, stern-faced but soft-eyed, with the kind of jaw that stayed clenched by default.

"So," she leaned forward, "you tracked your thoughts this week?"

He pulled a crumpled paper from his wallet, flattened it awkwardly, then slid it across the table like it was something shameful.

Angelique glanced at the entries. Six incidents. All brief. All intense. The most recent one was just yesterday:

Driving on the highway, passed by a tanker truck. Thought: If this skids, I'll drown. Instant spike—cold sweat, heart pounding, same as always.

"Good job," she said, looking up. "You didn't avoid the feeling. You mapped it."

Arman scoffed. "Doesn't feel like much of an achievement when I still feel like a five-year-old every time water's involved."

Angelique's voice softened. "I don't think five-year-olds deserve that tone."

That quieted him. For a moment, he looked away—watching the rain ripple down the glass.

"Last week," he said, "you asked if there'd been any work done before. I didn't tell you everything."

"I sensed that," she said, without judgment.

He gave a dry chuckle. "About two years ago, my wife took me to this past life regression therapist. I thought it was bull—until... something happened."

Angelique folded her hands loosely in her lap. "Go on."

"I was under... hypnotized or whatever. And I saw this boy. I was barefoot. The ground was hot. There were stone steps... and then water. A lake maybe. I remember leaning in to touch it, slipping—then nothing. I couldn't breathe. My lungs were screaming. I was maybe six."

The air in the room grew still, even though outside the world kept moving.

"And ever since then," Arman whispered, "I keep dreaming of looking up at the surface, with light just out of reach."

Angelique didn't blink. "It scared you."

"It felt real," he said. "Too real. But the therapist kept telling me to 'forgive the moment and let it go.' And I wanted to scream: how do you forgive dying?"

Angelique nodded slowly. "You don't. You *understand* it."

She leaned back, gaze drifting toward the antique mirror on the side table—its edges faded, its surface gently fogged. A portal, in its own quiet way.

"Whether that was a past life or just your nervous system offering you a metaphor," she continued, "your body remembers something it believes it never survived. That's the thread we'll follow—not to dismiss it, but to *complete* the loop."

Arman was quiet.

"I didn't come here for incense and metaphors," he said, trying to sound gruff. "I came here because my life's smaller than it should be. I won't go to beaches. Can't get in a pool. Panic if I even step on a boat."

The Boy Who Feared Everything

“Good,” she said simply.

He blinked. “Good?”

“It means the wound is accessible. And that means healing is possible.”

From her drawer, she pulled out a folded printout. A basic worksheet, but intentional.

“Gradual Exposure Plan: Week 1”

Simple tasks. Controlled breathwork. A list of imagined scenarios rated on his fear scale from 1 to 10. No real water—yet. Just confronting mental images. Letting the body adapt in safety.

“This isn’t about jumping into the deep end,” Angelique said. “This is about walking your nervous system back home.”

Arman stared at the sheet, as if it might bite him.

“I hate this,” he muttered.

“You’re allowed to,” she smiled. “Just don’t quit on the little boy who drowned before he could grow up.”

His hand trembled slightly as he took the paper.

Outside, the rain slowed to a drizzle. A soft light bloomed from behind the clouds—muted, but enough.

Angelique sat still, watching him fold the worksheet and tuck it away.

“You once asked if this phobia made you broken,” she said quietly. “I think... maybe it’s your soul’s way of trying to remember something unfinished. And your body? It’s just the loyal guardian.”

Arman nodded, but didn’t speak.

As he stood to leave, he looked over his shoulder.

“I’ll do it,” he said. “But if I drown again in my sleep, I’m suing you in the astral realm.”

Angelique chuckled. “I’ll represent myself. I’ve got a good

21 Mirrors

track record there.”

He left, the door clicking softly behind him.

And once again, the mirror caught a flicker—not a reflection, but a ripple—like water. Just for a second.

* * *

The door creaked open at exactly 10:45 a.m. this time. Early again. But not anxious-early—*ready*-early.

Angelique noticed it instantly.

There was a subtle difference in how Arman moved today. Less like someone trying to shrink into the chair, more like someone learning to exist inside their skin.

She offered a quiet nod as he sat down.

“How’d the sheet go?” she asked, folding her legs beneath her chair.

He shrugged, but with less heaviness than before. “Didn’t do all of it. But I imagined walking toward a swimming pool. Ten times. Breathed through it. I didn’t puke. I call that progress.”

“Did your hands shake?”

“Only the first few times.”

Angelique smiled. “Then your nervous system is learning safety. Beautiful.”

Arman leaned back. “Still had the dream, though.”

“Same one?”

He nodded. “The boy. Underwater. This time... I saw his face clearer. He looked like me. But younger. Like six. His eyes weren’t scared, though. They were... resigned.”

Angelique’s eyes softened. “Then it’s time we speak to him.”

He furrowed his brows. “What do you mean?”

She stood up, crossed the room and dimmed the lights just

The Boy Who Feared Everything

slightly. The incense holder from the shelf was set aside today. Instead, she rolled out a grounding mat across the floor.

"Today," she said gently, "we begin somatic work. Light imagery. Light breathwork. Just enough to let your body know it's safe to meet the water again—even in memory."

He didn't protest. Just sat cross-legged where she indicated, his back straight but not rigid. She sat opposite him, a mirror of calm.

"Close your eyes," she said. "You're not in danger. You're not being tested. We're simply watching a memory like it's a movie on a screen you can pause anytime."

His breath shallowed at first, but she guided him into a pattern—inhale four, hold four, exhale six. Again. Again.

"Now," she said softly, "I want you to picture the boy. You can see the stone steps. The lake. It's warm. But the boy is not afraid yet. He's just there."

Arman's face twitched. "He's crouching."

"Go to him," Angelique said. "Not physically. Just imagine you're sitting beside him. Say something. What do you want to tell him?"

There was a pause. A long one.

Then, voice cracked and small, Arman whispered, "You don't have to prove anything."

Angelique stayed still. Letting the words settle like dew.

"I've lived your fear," he continued. "I carried it for forty years. But it's not yours anymore."

The air grew thick with something unnameable.

Angelique, still grounded in her breath, waited before speaking again.

"Now place your hand on your chest," she instructed. "Tell your body: This is now. That was then. We made it."

21 *Mirrors*

Arman did.

A full inhale. And for the first time... a clean exhale.

Angelique opened her eyes.

"When we survive trauma," she said, "we often forget to update our body's memory. Today, your body saw the truth—it lived."

He looked up, dazed but lighter.

"Do I... need to do that every day?"

"No," she smiled. "Just often enough that the boy inside doesn't feel like he's drowning alone."

* * *

Back in her chair, Angelique scribbled quietly in her notes. She felt it again—that tug in the ether. That quiet, sacred knowing.

She glanced at the mirror. It was still. No ripple today.

But something else had shifted.

A feather floated down just outside the window, slow as forgiveness.

Arman stood to leave, face unreadable but no longer guarded.

At the door, he turned. "I still think all this spiritual stuff is... out there."

Angelique smirked. "Healing doesn't need your belief. Just your willingness."

He almost smiled. Then left.

And across the room, Angelique reached for the smooth onyx at her throat.

"Another ghost met," she whispered.

Eleven

The Woman with the Heavy Hands



It was already twelve minutes past the hour.

Angelique's eyes drifted toward the window. The afternoon sun scattered its warmth across her floor, casting long, golden lines like soft prison bars across the grey rug. She didn't usually glance at the time this much. But Vidhi was never late.

Something about this delay felt... different.

She leaned back in her chair, fingers loosely laced together, and allowed her body to soften. Sometimes clients were late because life happened. And sometimes, because they were wrestling ghosts in their cars, deciding if they were strong enough to walk through the door.

She closed her eyes for a moment.

And just like that, the past found her.

Vidhi had walked in that day like she had a hundred things to do and was checking therapy off the list between meetings. She was dressed in a crisp white shirt tucked into tailored beige trousers.

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Hair in a clean bun. Lipstick sharp, smile sharper.

"Hi, sorry, I had to take a call from work. Hope I'm not late," she'd said, dropping into the couch like she owned it.

Angelique had noticed how her tone was all lightness, and her body — all armor.

They began the intake. Anxiety. Feeling "stuck." Work stress. Mild sleep disruption. "Probably just burnout." Maybe even "low-grade depression." Vidhi had come in with the language of someone who'd done her Google homework, neat and clinical.

But Angelique didn't rush.

She noticed how Vidhi joked quickly when things got too quiet. How she over explained, then underplayed. How she referred to herself as "emotionally high-maintenance" and "probably too sensitive for corporate."

Angelique had simply nodded. Letting her dance her dance.

Until Vidhi had paused mid-sentence, touched her necklace nervously, and muttered, "Anyway, I'm used to people getting tired of me."

That's when Angelique knew. The real story was buried far beneath the boardrooms and brand campaigns. This wasn't just work stress. This was a lifetime of silent bruises wrapped in professionalism.

Back to present, the door finally creaked open.

Vidhi stood there — breathless, wide-eyed, holding an iced Americano like a peace offering.

"Don't kill me," she said. "The meeting from hell ran late and my cab driver decided today was the day to debate traffic with Google Maps."

Angelique smiled gently. "I'm just glad you're here."

Vidhi sat down, her shoulders slumping. The coffee rested on her lap, untouched.

The Woman with the Heavy Hands

There was something in her energy today — a tension behind the usual banter. A kind of quiet tremble under all the sarcasm.

“I almost didn’t come today,” she confessed, eyes not meeting hers.

Angelique tilted her head. “What made you come anyway?”

Vidhi looked down, voice soft. “Because last night... I felt like the walls were caving in. And I couldn’t breathe. And I didn’t want to be alone with that.”

Angelique nodded. “Thank you for showing up.”

And just like that, the real session began.

* * *

Vidhi clutched the iced coffee now, the condensation leaving ghost marks on her fingers. But she still hadn’t taken a sip.

“I don’t know what’s wrong with me,” she said finally. “I’ve done all the things. The routines. The journaling. Gratitude lists. Therapy. Still, there are days I feel like I’m drowning in molasses.”

Angelique didn’t answer right away. Instead, she observed Vidhi’s posture — one leg jittering, nails bitten to the quick. Her makeup was perfect, but beneath the mascara, her eyes were clouded. Like the kind of tired that sleep couldn’t fix.

“You said something cracked last night,” Angelique said. “What was the trigger?”

Vidhi looked away. “It was something stupid. My boyfriend said I didn’t answer his texts for three hours, and then he ghosted me the rest of the day. Blocked me, actually.”

She laughed, but it cracked midway. “I know how this looks. Another dramatic story from someone who should know better.”

Angelique's voice was steady. "It doesn't look like anything. I'm just here to understand what it felt like for you."

Vidhi went quiet. Then her voice dropped, smaller. "It felt like... I was twelve again. Like I was waiting for someone who promised to come, but never did."

Angelique's eyes softened. "What happened when you were twelve?"

A beat of silence. And then—

"My father would say he's coming to my school play or some dumb event. I'd keep looking for him in the crowd. Always the last row. Always thinking maybe this time. And then later that night, he'd act like he was never supposed to come at all. Like I'd made it up."

There it was. The ache beneath the sarcasm. The trembling child inside the high-functioning woman.

Angelique asked gently, "Was he... safe?"

Vidhi's throat moved like she'd swallowed glass. "Not always. Emotionally, never. Physically, rarely. And sexually... sometimes."

The last word barely escaped her lips, like it had waited decades to be spoken aloud.

Angelique didn't flinch. She anchored the room in stillness. No gasps. No rush to console. Just pure, unwavering presence.

"Thank you for trusting me with that," she said softly.

Vidhi wiped her cheek, surprised by her own tears. "It's stupid. It happened years ago."

Angelique leaned forward just slightly. "The body doesn't keep time like the mind does. It only knows memory. And yours has been holding this alone for a long time."

Vidhi exhaled sharply, like something inside her cracked just enough to let a little light in.

The Woman with the Heavy Hands

"I think that's why I stayed so long with Karan," she admitted. "My ex. He was... charismatic. Said all the right things. But he made me feel insane half the time. I kept telling myself it wasn't abuse. It wasn't physical. It was just... me being too much."

Angelique noted the words:

Too much.

A phrase women like Vidhi were taught to swallow like medicine.

"What did 'too much' look like, according to him?" she asked.

"Crying. Needing reassurance. Asking him not to flirt with waitresses in front of me. Noticing when he was cold. Bringing it up."

She paused. "Having needs."

Angelique let the silence stretch. She knew that silence wasn't empty. It was full of answers waiting to be heard.

"Vidhi, the pattern you're carrying isn't just yours," she said gently. "You were taught to normalize what hurt. You adapted to survive."

Vidhi nodded slowly. "I always feel like I have to earn love. Perform for it. And when it does show up... I don't trust it."

Angelique could feel it now — the heavy hands. The invisible weight of a childhood where love was doled out in crumbs and threats. Of womanhood spent reshaping herself into someone more palatable. Of a nervous system that had learned to flinch at intimacy.

"I'm tired of fighting myself," Vidhi whispered. "I don't want to live like this anymore."

Angelique smiled, not with pity, but with recognition. "Then let's help your body remember that safety doesn't have to be a performance. That love isn't a prize to win."

Vidhi had stopped fidgeting now.

There was a stillness in the room that didn't feel forced — like her body had finally stopped bracing for an explosion that wasn't coming.

Angelique leaned back slightly, watching her with that same quiet that had unsettled and soothed a hundred clients before her.

"Vidhi," she said, voice low, almost rhythm-like. "You're not broken. You're adapted."

That one landed like honey — thick, slow, and deeply needed.

"I want us to begin with a few different paths. We won't choose just one. You've lived with too many cages — I want you to have choice now."

Vidhi tilted her head, curious. "Okay..."

Angelique continued, now reaching for her small obsidian journal — a soft, ancient-looking thing, its pages already thinned with years of listening.

"There's a therapy called *Transference-Focused Psychotherapy*," she explained. "It helps us look at the patterns you unconsciously repeat in relationships — especially with authority figures or people you grow close to. It's not about blame. It's about lighting up the dark corners."

Vidhi gave a small nod, eyes alert.

"And then there's *Mentalization-Based Therapy*," Angelique added. "It helps rebuild the bridge between feeling and understanding — especially when trauma makes it hard to know what's yours, what's theirs, and what's just the storm."

"That sounds... accurate," Vidhi murmured.

"And," Angelique said, with a flicker of a smile, "we'll weave in

The Woman with the Heavy Hands

DBT. Dialectical Behavior Therapy. Especially for emotional regulation. It gives your nervous system a language. Tools for the panic before it breaks the surface.”

Vidhi looked away for a second, then back. “That doesn’t sound like therapy. That sounds like... Armour.”

Angelique smiled softly. “Maybe it’s both.”

Then, gently, she pushed a small, smooth stone across the table — polished labradorite, shifting blue and violet like rain trapped in rock.

“This is a grounding stone,” she said. “But more than that — it holds stormlight. Keep it on you, not for magic... but for memory.”

Vidhi didn’t ask what it meant. She just closed her fingers around it like she’d been waiting for it her whole life.

Angelique continued, her voice almost a whisper now, as though she was speaking to something beyond the room.

“I want you to do something this week. When you feel your chest tighten — or your thoughts spiral — place your hand on your stomach. Close your eyes. And ask, ‘How old do I feel right now?’”

Vidhi blinked.

“That’s how you meet the part of you that’s stuck,” Angelique said. “That’s how we begin.”

Vidhi stared at her for a moment too long — like she was trying to place Angelique. Like she was both inside this world and just beyond it.

“Can I ask you something?”

Angelique tilted her head.

“Are you...” Vidhi hesitated, then laughed at herself. “Never mind. It sounds stupid.”

“No such thing,” Angelique said, gently.

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Vidhi looked down at the stone. “Are you... human?”

The question wasn’t mocking. It was raw. Childlike. And somehow, deeply earned.

Angelique didn’t answer. She only smiled — the kind of smile that didn’t need to explain itself.

The mirror behind her caught the light strangely just then. Just a shimmer, like something ancient blinked.

As Vidhi gathered her things, there was a new stillness in her steps. She wasn’t lighter. Not yet. But she was less alone in the heaviness.

Just before she reached the door, Angelique’s voice floated to her one last time:

*“Some children carry wounds that stretch across lifetimes.
But the moment they name them, the healing begins —
not just for them, but for the bloodlines behind them.”*

Twelve

The Man Who Drank His Dreams



The room smelled faintly of sandalwood and old stories. Outside, the sky sulked in a soft grey, like it was holding back tears of its own.

Angelique entered the space quietly, her footsteps softened by the thick rug that had caught decades' worth of confessions. She noticed him immediately — already seated, already slouched, already somewhere else.

He looked up, the corners of his lips trying to smile but not quite making it. "Hey," he said, voice low, gravelly — hangover breath soaked in shame.

She nodded, warm and slow, setting her notebook aside. This wasn't the kind of session that required a clipboard right away.

"You found the place alright?" she asked, more as a gentle entry point than a real question.

"Yeah. Maps didn't judge me for being five minutes late," he said with a weak smile.

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She returned it, gently. "I'm Angelique."

"Dev."

A beat.

He looked around the room — the salt lamp in the corner, the shelves of books with spines too wise, the antique mirror that seemed to blink when you weren't looking.

Dev rubbed his eyes. "Sorry if I look like hell. I had... one of those nights."

She didn't flinch. "Want to tell me about it?"

He shrugged. "Woke up on the couch again. One shoe on. TV still playing some reality show I didn't even start. Classic."

"Do you remember what happened before you passed out?"

He laughed dryly. "A couple beers. Then whisky. Maybe a shot of tequila. The usual playlist."

Angelique tilted her head. "That's quite the mix."

"I guess I was hoping it'd cancel me out," he said, eyes drifting toward the window. "Like... subtraction by addition. Keep pouring in until I disappear."

That line hung heavy in the room.

She didn't chase it. Just waited.

Dev exhaled slowly. "I didn't come here because of the drinking. I mean, yeah, I drink. But it's not... like a problem, problem. I just feel..."

He paused, then shrugged.

"Low. Empty. Most mornings feel like déjà vu with worse lighting."

"And the drinking... helps with that?"

"It helps me sleep. Helps me not think. Helps me not hate myself for wasting all the things I used to be good at."

Angelique's gaze softened. "What were you good at?"

He smiled again — this time wistful, boyish. "Design."

The Man Who Drank His Dreams

Animation. I used to draw for hours as a kid. I got into one of the top colleges. People said I'd 'make it big.'"

He chuckled bitterly.

"And then... life happened. Deadlines. Bills. Burnout. I took a remote job with minimal brain activity. And now... most of my art is half-finished or hidden in drafts I don't open anymore."

Angelique folded her hands. "You stopped making art when you started drinking more?"

He looked at her like she'd peeled something raw.

"No one's ever said it like that. But... yeah. Maybe."

A long pause.

"It's like the part of me that could create things started drowning the day I needed help and couldn't admit it."

Angelique let that silence bloom.

"Can I ask about your relationship with your father?" she said, softly — not poking, but following a hunch.

Dev didn't answer right away. Just laughed again — that same broken-glass laugh.

"My dad used to call art 'time pass.' He thought I was wasting my youth. Told me men who doodle end up poor."

Angelique let that land. "And did he see you win awards? Get into one of the top schools?"

Dev's jaw clenched. "Yeah. But he still forwarded me MBA links every week. Said it was 'just in case this art thing doesn't work out.'"

A beat.

"I think I stopped believing in myself the day I realized he never really did."

His voice cracked, and for a moment, he looked like a boy still sitting at the dinner table waiting for a nod that never

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came.

Angelique whispered gently, "That's a hard wound to carry."

He looked away, blinking rapidly. "That's why I drink. Not for the buzz. Not even for the sleep. I drink so I don't feel the hole."

She leaned forward, her voice like water over stone.

"I don't think you're trying to escape. I think you're trying to remember who you were before you gave up on yourself."

Dev looked at her — really looked, like she was holding a candle inside a cave he hadn't visited in years.

* * *

There was a stillness in the room now — the kind that settles after truth has been spoken aloud. Not dramatic. Not heavy. Just honest.

Dev had shifted in his seat, arms loosely folded now. The tension in his jaw had softened, but his shoulders still carried the invisible weight of years unspoken.

Angelique's voice came like a soft breeze.

"Do you remember your first blackout?"

Dev paused. Then nodded.

"Second year of college. A friend's birthday. I was already three beers down before we got to the club. Someone handed me shots. I said yes to all of them. I always do."

He looked at the floor.

"Next thing I knew, I woke up outside my dorm. Someone had dropped me off. No memory of how I got there."

"Did it scare you?"

"No. That's the thing. It didn't. I was almost... relieved. Like — at least I got to skip a few hours of being me."

The Man Who Drank His Dreams

Angelique didn't flinch. "And now?"

Dev swallowed. "Now it's just... blurry. I drink to soften the days. But sometimes, I wake up and don't remember who I texted, or what I posted. Once I even missed a client Zoom call. Lied and said I had food poisoning."

His voice was tinged with shame. Not performative. Just weary.

Angelique nodded, still grounded. "When you drink, do you feel more like yourself, or less?"

He thought about it.

"More... in the beginning. I feel confident. Like I can speak my mind. I dance. I flirt. I feel funny again. But somewhere between drink three and six... I disappear. I'm watching myself from somewhere far away."

She leaned in just slightly. "That's called depersonalisation. It's the nervous system's way of saying: *This pain doesn't feel survivable. So we're going to float above it instead.*"

Dev blinked. "Yeah. That's exactly it."

Angelique tapped gently on her armrest, then reached for the leather-bound journal on her side table. She flipped it open, tore out a page, and began drawing a rough shape — a kind of loose body silhouette.

"We're going to try something," she said. "This is called *Self-Mapping*. I want you to close your eyes. Take a breath. Now tell me: where in your body do you feel most disconnected when you're drinking?"

He closed his eyes.

"My chest. And my hands. They feel like they don't belong to me."

She circled those areas.

"Now... where do you feel safest? Even if it's small. Even if

it's just for a second."

He took his time.

"My wrists. Weirdly. They always stay warm. Even in winter."

She circled those in soft blue.

Angelique handed him the paper. "This is your first map. It'll change as we work together. But for now, it's a start. This map is you coming home."

Dev stared at it, like it was both foreign and familiar.

Angelique's voice dropped low, intimate.

"When the soul is wounded young — when it's told it's too sensitive, or not enough, or only conditionally lovable — it starts looking for exits. Alcohol is one such exit. But there's a braver path, Dev. One where you stop running."

He looked up, eyes glassy. "What if I don't know how?"

"You don't have to know. You just have to want to."

They sat there a while, both holding silence like an offering.

Just before the session ended, Angelique asked, "Would you be open to some inner child work next time?"

He smiled softly. "Depends. Will he even talk to me?"

She smiled back.

"Not at first. But he's been waiting for years. I think he'll be glad you finally showed up."

* * *

This was his second session. Dev looked different.

Still the same black hoodie, still the unshaven stubble, but something in his posture had changed. Less crumpled. More present. Like maybe — just maybe — he'd remembered how to sit *inside* his body.

The Man Who Drank His Dreams

He walked in with a half-smile.

"I dreamt of water," he said, before even sitting down.

Angelique's gaze lifted, alert but calm.

"Tell me."

He slumped into the chair. "It wasn't like any dream I've had. I was underwater, but not drowning. I was... suspended. And there was this boy. Maybe six or seven. Curly hair. Big eyes. He looked like me, but also... not."

She stayed quiet.

"He wasn't scared. Just floating. But I was panicking, trying to reach him, screaming through the water. And then he spoke. Like, *in my head*. Said: 'Stop saving me. Just be with me.'"

Angelique felt something catch in her chest — that quiet click of truth unlocking.

"And what did you do?" she asked.

Dev's voice broke just slightly.

"I stopped swimming. I just... floated. Next to him."

Silence. Holy silence.

Angelique leaned forward, elbows on knees.

"That boy," she said softly, "is your inner compass. The part of you that knew how to feel before the world taught you to numb. Before love became conditional. Before alcohol became your ocean."

He nodded, wiping the corner of his eye roughly. "Why did I feel so... *safe* with him?"

"Because he's always been waiting for you," she said. "Not to fix him. Just to witness him."3

Dev swallowed. "I didn't think I was one of those 'inner child' people."

"You are," she said with a smile. "We all are. Some of us just bury the child deeper."

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She let a beat pass, then added, “Would you be open to meeting him again — consciously, this time? Through a small exercise?”

Dev nodded. “Yeah.”

Angelique slid a piece of paper toward him.

“Write him a letter. From *you now*, to *him then*. Tell him what hurt. What you’ve learned. What you’re still learning. Let it be clumsy, if it needs to be. Let it be honest.”

He picked it up like it might dissolve.

“And Dev,” she said gently, “you can’t numb the pain *and* hear the message at the same time.”

He blinked, startled. She wasn’t accusing him. She was inviting him.

“I’m not going to force your hand. But if you’re open... I can refer you to a quiet place. Not a clinic with white walls — something more holistic. A short-term sobriety program where the goal isn’t just detox, but reconnection. No pressure. Just an option.”

He nodded, voice hoarse. “Okay.”

“And if you’re not ready for that just yet... I’d still like you to track your ‘emotional drinking.’ Not just how much — but what emotion you’re drinking *with*. Or *from*. Start mapping the story.”

He took the notes like they were lifelines, not tasks.

“Sometimes,” Angelique said, “healing isn’t about getting stronger. It’s about finally letting go of what you were never meant to carry alone.”

* * *

As Dev stepped out into the morning light, the world felt no

The Man Who Drank His Dreams

different — but inside him, something sacred had stirred.
A boy underwater was no longer alone.

Thirteen

The Mirror That Lied



The first thing Angelique noticed about him was his silence. Not the awkward kind, or even the polite kind. But the curated kind. The kind that knew how to fill a room without making noise.

Karan sat with his ankle resting on one knee, an effortless air of control. His shirt was pressed, his jaw clean-shaven, and his cologne had that sharp, citrusy aftershock that tried too hard to say, *I have my life together*.

But Angelique had been at this long enough. Control was often the prettiest mask worn by the most chaotic minds.

She glanced down at her notes from their earlier sessions. Concerns about “career stagnation.” A vague mention of “feeling under-stimulated.” Not a word about pain. Which, ironically, told her everything.

“Good to see you again,” she said, gently.

He nodded. “You too.”

The Mirror That Lied

There was something about the way he said it. Too smooth. Like silk over glass.

"How's the week been?" she asked, knowing the answer wouldn't be simple.

Karan tilted his head slightly, thoughtful. "Productive. Closed two major deals. Hit the gym five times. Slept better than usual."

A perfectly stacked answer. Measurable. Presentable. Palatable.

Angelique leaned in slightly. "And emotionally?"

He blinked, caught off guard. The pause was microscopic but telling.

"Well," he said with a half-smile, "I don't usually measure my emotions in weekly reports."

Angelique smiled back. "Maybe it's time you started."

There it was again — the smallest flicker in his eyes. Like a storm far out at sea.

Karan looked away briefly, fingers tightening around his coffee cup. "I've been thinking about the concept of failure," he said eventually.

"Tell me more."

He exhaled slowly. "People talk about healing like it's this linear path. But some days I feel like I've built a fortress out of who I *pretend* to be... and then hate myself for needing the fortress at all."

Angelique felt the shift. The persona was loosening.

"And what's inside the fortress?" she asked softly.

Silence.

Then, finally, he spoke:

"A boy. Angry. Lonely. Terrified of being abandoned."

Angelique let the quiet bloom between them. These were

the moments therapy worked its quiet magic.

She reached for her onyx pendant — that same instinctual gesture — thumb brushing over it like a tuning fork for truth.

A beat passed. Then Karan spoke again, tone less performative this time:

“I saw something on Instagram the other day... My ex. Vidhi. She’s doing better, I think. Looked... lighter.”

Funny, she thought, watching him adjust the cuff of his sleeve again, a ghost from Vidhi’s past, now sitting across from me. The universe never wastes a pattern.

Angelique didn’t reply. She just smiled — the kind of smile you wear when you already know the ending.

“Do you miss her?” she asked, the question not sharp, but sincere.

“I miss being important,” he said, almost too quickly.

There it was. The tell.

She didn’t prod. She just let him sit in it.

* * *

He was quieter this session. Not performative quiet, but the kind that meant something was finally ready to surface.

Angelique leaned back in her chair, palms resting softly on the armrest like open wings. “Tell me about the mirror,” she said gently.

Karan’s brow furrowed. “What mirror?”

“The one you seem to measure yourself against.”

He gave a tired smile. “The usual one, I guess. Expectations. The ones I’ve set. The ones my parents set. The ones society expects me to meet by thirty-five.”

“And whose reflection do you see when you look into it?”

The Mirror That Lied

He didn't answer right away. Just stared at his hands.

"Depends on the day," he finally said. "Sometimes I see a successful man with charisma and sharp suits. Other days... I see a scared little boy who learned that love has terms and praise has a price."

There it was. The fracture. The split self.

Angelique's voice softened. "What were the terms?"

He inhaled deeply. "Be perfect. Be clever. Don't cry. Don't talk about what you want. Just want what you're given. And earn your place, always."

"And if you didn't?"

Karan's jaw tensed. "You became invisible."

She nodded slowly. "Sounds like invisibility was used as punishment."

He looked up, the mask slipping further. "My mother would withdraw when I disappointed her. Not shout. Not punish. Just... vanish emotionally. Like she didn't recognize me anymore."

"And that trained you to perform," Angelique said gently. "To survive."

A long pause. He stared down at his cup, swirling what little remained.

Angelique continued, "And when did that performance start turning into self-hate?"

"When I realized I couldn't keep it up," he said, voice flat. "When I started losing relationships. Real ones. Because I couldn't handle being seen fully."

She scribbled something invisible in her mind.

Core wound: conditional love.

Defence: Narcissistic mask.

Symptom: chronic loneliness masked by charm.

21 Mirrors

Angelique waited for a beat before leaning forward slightly.

"Have you ever tried seeing yourself *without* the mirror?"

He scoffed. "What does that even mean?"

"Without distortion. Without performance. Without measuring. Just... as you are."

Karan gave a short laugh — sharp and hollow. "I don't think I know who I am without all of that."

"Then that's what we'll uncover," she said. "Layer by layer."

He looked skeptical. "You think this can be fixed?"

"No," Angelique said simply. "But it can be *understood*. And when something is understood, it can be transformed."

She let that land.

"Tell me," she asked, "when you're alone... really alone... what part of yourself scares you the most?"

He blinked. "The emptiness."

"What do you imagine lives there?"

"Need. Weakness. Shame. That if I stop being impressive, people will leave."

She said nothing. Just met his eyes.

And in that moment, for perhaps the first time in years, Karan allowed someone to look directly into the hollowness — not with pity, but with presence.

* * *

The chair was the same. The man in it, slightly less so.

Karan slouched, but not carelessly. He looked... softened. Less like marble. More like clay that had finally touched rain.

"I tried what you said," he began without preamble. "The 'no mirror' thing."

Angelique raised an eyebrow. "And?"

The Mirror That Lied

"I panicked."

A small smile tugged at her lips. "Good. That means you met something real."

He laughed, but it sounded less like deflection this time. "You don't make it easy, you know."

"Truth rarely is."

A beat passed between them. Then Angelique asked, "Do you remember how we talked about defense mechanisms?"

"Yeah. How they keep us alive, but also keep us stuck."

She nodded. "The narcissistic defense isn't about vanity. It's about pain management. When a child's true self isn't mirrored, they create a false one. One that is charming, untouchable, impressive."

He was silent for a long time. "So... I'm basically an emotional prosthetic."

"No," Angelique said softly. "You're a survivor who learned to build armor from glass. Beautiful, sharp, but see-through. And now the weight of holding it all is making your arms tired."

Karan blinked. Hard.

She reached for her notepad, scribbled a few phrases before saying, "I want to try something today. It's called *parts work*. You've heard of Internal Family Systems?"

He nodded vaguely.

Angelique continued, "We all carry multiple 'selves' inside us. Think of them like sub-personalities. Managers. Exiles. Protectors. Each one with a role. I want you to close your eyes and meet one."

He hesitated, then leaned back and did as told.

"Now," she said gently, "bring your awareness to the part of you that works hardest to impress. The one that smiles when it's crumbling. What do you see?"

He paused. "He's in a tuxedo."

She smiled slightly. "Of course he is."

"He's giving a speech at some award show. But he looks... scared. Like if he stops talking, someone will boo."

Angelique's voice softened to a whisper. "What do you want to say to him?"

Karan's eyes fluttered behind his lids. "That he can sit down now. That I'm tired."

"Can he hear you?"

A pause. "I think so. He's... stepping off the stage."

"And what else is there?"

A flicker of something passed across his brow. "A little boy. Maybe seven or eight. Sitting backstage. No one's looking at him."

Angelique let silence hold the moment like cupped hands.

"Can you walk toward him?"

Karan nodded.

"What does he say?"

He swallowed. "Nothing. But he looks like he's been waiting for years."

"Then sit with him," she said. "No speeches. No performance. Just presence."

He sat in silence, breathing shifting from shallow to steady.

When he opened his eyes, they glistened—but not with pride.

With grief.

Angelique gave him a moment before saying, "That little boy is your truth. Not the one in the tuxedo. He doesn't need an audience. He needs a witness."

Karan exhaled like something heavy had been released.

"So what now?" he asked. "Do I just keep visiting him?"

"You start by acknowledging he exists," Angelique said.

The Mirror That Lied

“Every time you feel the urge to perform, pause. Ask: *Who’s speaking right now—the child, or the actor?* That’s your first practice.”

He nodded. Then hesitated. “Can I tell you something weird?”

She smiled. “Always.”

“After last week’s session, I had this... dream. I was standing in front of a mirror, and when I looked in, I saw two versions of me. One was polished, confident, the usual. The other was a version I’d never seen before. Scared, raw, but peaceful. He said something to me.”

Angelique leaned forward, intrigued. “What did he say?”

Karan stared into the space between them. “You can come home now.”

The room went still.

Across from him, Angelique placed a hand lightly over her heart and whispered, “Then that’s where we begin.”

Before ending the session, Angelique gently handed him a small card with a prompt written in her delicate handwriting:

“Describe the version of you who exists when no one’s watching.

Where did he go?

How does he return?”

Karan read it, nodding. “Feels... terrifying.”

“Which means it’s working,” she smiled.

* * *

As he left the room, the antique mirror on the far wall flickered slightly in the afternoon light.

Angelique’s gaze lingered on it for a moment—watching as Karan’s reflection seemed to shimmer, not with distortion...

21 Mirrors

...but as though a soul was stepping a little closer to its own center.

She whispered softly to the quiet space:

When you stop performing long enough...

the child you left behind might finally hear your footsteps returning.

Fourteen

The Soldier Who Still Heard Gunfire



The therapy room smelled faintly of vetiver and sandalwood. The kind of scent that said: you're safe now, even if you don't believe it yet.

Angelique was rearranging the pillow on the grey armchair when she heard the shuffle of feet outside. Not the hurried kind. The heavy, reluctant kind—like a man dragging a lifetime behind him.

The knock was followed not by his voice, but hers.

"He wouldn't come in unless I spoke to you first," said the woman, stepping into the room with an apologetic half-smile. "I'm Aarti. His daughter-in-law."

Angelique nodded. "Of course."

She motioned for Aarti to sit, and the woman did, perching on the edge of the couch like she didn't want to make an impression. Her dupatta was slightly crumpled, as if she'd folded it in her hands too many times before walking in.

"He's not... like this all the time," Aarti said. "But it's getting worse."

Angelique waited.

"He fought in the Kargil war," Aarti continued. "Back then he was just 'Major.' Now everyone calls him 'Colonel Saab,' but at home... it's like we're all still stuck somewhere in that snow."

She looked down, twisting a thin silver ring around her finger. "He screams in his sleep. He once locked himself in the bathroom for hours after the Diwali crackers went off early. Last week... he grabbed Aarav—my son—by the shoulders and yelled at him for dropping a toy tank. My son is six."

Angelique's gaze softened. "That must've been terrifying."

"It was," Aarti said quietly. "But what scares me more is that afterward, he cried. Locked himself in the room and wept like a child. I've never seen him like that."

A silence sat between them. One of those rare, honest ones.

"He keeps saying he doesn't need help. That it's just 'memories.' That he's not crazy." Aarti's voice cracked. "But I can't... I can't let my kids grow up afraid of their grandfather."

Angelique nodded once. "Let me meet him."

Aarti stood, hesitated, and then said, "He's proud. Doesn't like weakness. If you ask about the war... he'll walk out."

Angelique offered her a smile that was both gentle and ancient. "I won't ask about the war."

She'd wait until the war came looking for him.

The door opened again—this time slower.

He walked in like a soldier still marching in boots. Even in civilian clothes, his spine stood at attention. Weathered face. Hard eyes. Thick silence.

"Colonel Malhotra," he said with a curt nod, not offering a hand.

The Soldier Who Still Heard Gunfire

“Angelique,” she replied simply, without rising. Power met power in that brief stillness.

He sat. Not to speak, but to observe.

Aarti slipped out of the room with a breath she’d been holding since she arrived.

The colonel didn’t look around. Didn’t fidget. Just sat, as if the chair was another checkpoint he was guarding.

After a long pause, he said gruffly, “I don’t believe in this.”

Angelique leaned back, folding her hands in her lap. “That’s alright. We can begin anyway.”

* * *

The ticking of the wall clock was too loud.

Colonel Malhotra’s jaw flexed every few seconds — a barely perceptible movement, like a man trying to keep time with something only he could hear. Not the clock. Not her voice. Something older. Something buried.

Angelique didn’t rush.

He hadn’t said a word since sitting. But his left leg hadn’t stopped shaking.

“You don’t have to talk,” she said softly, “but I’d like you to tell me what happens in your body... when the silence gets too loud.”

He didn’t respond. Not with words.

But then, slowly, he unclenched a fist that had been closed since he walked in.

His voice, when it came, was a low growl. “There’s a ringing in my ears. Like a shell just landed too close. Even when everything’s quiet, it’s like I’m still there.”

Angelique stayed still. “Where’s there?”

He exhaled. Heavy. Loaded.

"You won't understand."

"I don't need to understand it," she said. "I just need you to help me see it through your eyes."

He laughed, but it wasn't amusement. It was defense.

"It was 1999. Kargil. High altitude. Low oxygen. No sleep. No clean water. Just... snow, blood, and static."

Angelique didn't take notes. She watched his breath instead. Quickening. Shallow.

He wasn't telling a story.

He was slipping into one.

"I lost my best friend," he said suddenly, eyes still locked on a point behind her shoulder. "Joshi. Had just cracked a joke about Samosas. Next second—gone. Just... gone."

Angelique's voice was a feather. "Do you remember what you felt in your body in that moment?"

He swallowed. "Nothing. That's the problem. I didn't feel anything. I just kept moving. Next mission. Next call. Next round. I buried him in snow with my own hands and reported in like he was an item off inventory."

He looked at her now — not for approval. For proof that she hadn't flinched.

She hadn't.

"I didn't cry. Not then. Not when I came home. Not even when I met his mother."

"And now?" she asked.

Colonel Malhotra's voice dropped into gravel. "Now I cry because a child dropped a toy tank."

Angelique nodded. "The body never forgets. It holds every unshed tear, every missed heartbeat, every silence you swallowed."

The Soldier Who Still Heard Gunfire

He didn't answer.

He didn't need to.

His shoulders had dropped by half an inch. His fingers had stopped curling into fists.

The war was no longer something behind him.

It was something **within** him.

And now —

it was beginning to come to the surface.

* * *

It had been six weeks since his first session.

Colonel Malhotra had not missed a single one.

The man who had once sat with arms crossed like a barricade now sat differently — still upright, but no longer on guard. His jaw still clenched sometimes, but now it relaxed when Angelique asked him to breathe.

Today, the blinds were slightly open.

He had asked for that.

A quiet sign of trust. A soldier's version of vulnerability.

"We'll begin where we left off," Angelique said gently, sliding her chair slightly to the side. "The moment just before you saw Joshi fall."

He gave a slight nod.

She held up two fingers and began the bilateral stimulation — fingers moving left to right, left to right, as his eyes followed the rhythm.

His breathing steadied, then hitched.

"I was just... laughing," he whispered, voice cracking. "He was saying how he'd kill for a chai and two samosas. And then—"

His eyes twitched as they followed her fingers. His hands clenched the sides of the chair.

"It was white. Just white. Noise. A scream. And I ran toward the sound."

Angelique's voice was soft but firm. "Stay there. What did your body feel?"

His breathing grew ragged. "Numb. But heavy. My legs were moving but I couldn't feel them. My chest—tight. Like a mountain was on it."

Left to right. Left to right.

"It wasn't just him I buried," he gasped, eyes welling. "I buried my ability to feel."

Angelique paused the motion gently and let the silence hold.

Then — the smallest of nods. "You did what you had to. But now, your nervous system is safe. You're not on that mountain anymore."

He exhaled. A long, shaky breath — the kind that only comes when something ancient releases its grip.

* * *

That was three weeks ago.

Now, he sat in her office once more — a cup of tea in his hand, the herbal kind he had once scoffed at.

They had tried **EMDR**, **body-focused mindfulness**, and some **somatic tracking**. There was even a journal now, one where he recorded memories not of battle, but of softness. His granddaughter's giggle. The smell of wet earth after rain. The way silence now didn't always feel like an ambush.

"It's strange," he said quietly, "how you can carry war inside you for decades, and still... the body wants to come home."

The Soldier Who Still Heard Gunfire

Angelique smiled.

“The body always wants to come home.”

He set down the cup. “You know, I used to think healing was weakness. That only the broken went to therapy. But now—” he looked at her, eyes steady, “I think I just didn’t know what peace felt like.”

She didn’t reply.

Instead, she stood, crossed to the small altar near her bookshelf, and lit a single marigold-colored candle.

It was something she only did when a session had shifted the current of the room.

As the scent of vetiver rose in the air, Colonel Malhotra stood to leave.

He paused at the door. Looked back. Then added, almost like a confession,

“I sleep through the night now. Most nights.”

Angelique placed a hand over her heart and bowed her head slightly — the quiet reverence of a priestess, not a doctor.

And as the door clicked shut behind him, she whispered — to no one and to something ancient:

“Even the loudest ghosts grow quiet

... when a soul remembers it is still alive.”

Fifteen

The Woman with Two Suns



The air was thick that morning—like something had gone still in the world just before a storm. Angelique felt it before she even stepped into her office, a faint pressure behind the eyes, like a signal from the unseen.

Her 11:00 a.m. had once again become a question mark on the calendar. Three missed appointments in a row. No messages. No cancellations. Only silence.

Until today.

The knock was soft, tentative, like the echo of someone unsure they belonged.

Angelique opened the door slowly. There she was.

Lavanya.

Hair unbrushed. Lip cracked. The fluorescent lights overhead weren't kind, and neither had she been—to herself.

"I'm sorry," Lavanya murmured, eyes darting away.

Angelique didn't flinch. She never did.

The Woman with Two Suns

“No need,” she said simply, stepping aside.

Lavanya walked in like someone entering a place she’d once felt safe but had since betrayed. Not Angelique—herself.

She folded into the chair without effort, like bones that no longer had instructions.

Angelique didn’t reach for the notepad. Not yet.

Lavanya stared at the floor. “It started with one night. Just one. I skipped the pill. Just wanted to feel clear-headed for once. Then two nights. Then I felt... electric.”

Angelique watched the invisible flicker of memory flash behind her eyes.

“I reorganized all my books by colour. Then by emotional impact. I painted my kitchen at 2 a.m. I made an entire Pinterest board of upcycled furniture. Everything felt *so loud*... but good-loud. Like music.”

“And then?” Angelique asked, voice feather-light.

Lavanya swallowed. “And then I crashed. It’s like I could hear every insult I’d ever swallowed in Dolby Digital. My boss said my work’s been slipping. I haven’t replied to my mom in days. I haven’t eaten properly. I don’t want to die. But I also... don’t care if I do.”

She said it so matter-of-factly, it hurt more than a scream would have.

Angelique’s fingers gently pressed together in her lap. Not in prayer, but in grounding. Tuning in. There was a sadness hovering near Lavanya that didn’t feel entirely her own. Like an inherited grief. Or something that lived between lifetimes.

“You’ve come back,” Angelique said, with a smile that didn’t ask for one in return.

“I didn’t know where else to go,” Lavanya replied.

Angelique nodded. “And you remembered that this space

exists even when your moods make you forget.”

Lavanya managed a small laugh. “You always talk like you’re casting spells.”

Angelique’s smile deepened. “Maybe healing is a form of magic.”

Lavanya looked down at her wrist, where a faint scar lingered—a healed-over wound, but not forgotten.

“I hate this about me. I hate that I always destroy things right when they’re starting to feel good.”

“You have two suns in you,” Angelique said gently. “One rises too early. The other too late. And you keep trying to live in their shared shadow.”

Lavanya’s eyes welled up, slowly. Not the kind of tears that begged to be seen. The kind that simply arrived.

“Do you think I’m broken?”

“No,” Angelique whispered. “I think you’re blazing. And learning how not to burn yourself.”

* * *

Angelique handed Lavanya a warm cup of chamomile. She didn’t ask if she wanted it. She just knew.

The silence was quieter now. Less sharp.

“How long did the high last?” Angelique asked gently, her pen resting on her thigh, uncapped but unused.

“Eleven days,” Lavanya murmured. “Then everything went grey. And sticky. Like wading through glue.”

Angelique nodded. “Textbook hypomanic onset followed by a depressive drop. You stopped your medication?”

“I just... wanted to feel like *me* again. But maybe *this* is me

The Woman with Two Suns

now. I don't know."

Angelique tilted her head, just slightly. "Sometimes we confuse ourselves with our symptoms. Because they've been there longer than some friendships."

Lavanya stared down at the cup in her hands. "Do you think this is all just chemical?"

"I think chemicals are the language your nervous system learned to speak after trauma," Angelique replied. "But the dictionary—it was written in your childhood."

Something shifted in Lavanya's jaw. A flicker. A freeze. A knowing.

Angelique leaned in.

"Do you want to talk about the early years?"

There was a pause. Then a breath. Then a quiet: "I had to raise my mother."

A sentence so simple. And yet, catastrophic.

"She was sweet when sober. But that wasn't often. I learned to hide the bottles before I learned to tie my shoelaces."

Angelique didn't interrupt.

Lavanya continued, voice low. "I had to keep the peace. Smile at school, cook dinner at 12, make sure she didn't overdose. My childhood was basically one long audition for stability."

"And no one saw?" Angelique asked softly.

"They praised me. Called me 'mature for my age.' Thought I was 'resilient.'" Lavanya laughed bitterly. "Turns out resilience is just trauma in high heels."

Angelique's pen scratched gently now.

Childified. Invisible. Parentified. Unprocessed grief. Dissociation through productivity. Trauma-linked hypomania.

Angelique looked up. "Have you ever tracked your moods?"

21 Mirrors

Lavanya shook her head. "Feels like trying to map weather in a hurricane."

"We'll start small," Angelique said, reaching into a drawer and pulling out a hand-drawn chart with sun, cloud, and storm icons across the top.

"You're giving me a colouring book?" Lavanya raised a brow.

"A code," Angelique corrected. "For your inner forecast. Each day, just circle the weather inside your chest. No labels. Just noticing."

Lavanya smiled for the first time that didn't have a crack behind it. "You're such a weirdo."

Angelique nodded with a smile. "Professionally."

Lavanya leaned back. "Is this how we fix it?"

"No," Angelique said. "But it's how we stop it from staying broken."

* * *

A month later, the sun came out for exactly forty-three minutes.

Lavanya had tracked it on her inner weather chart. A tiny gold dot inked beside a series of storm clouds. She'd even written:

"Didn't hate music today."

Angelique noticed the shift the moment she walked in.

Hair brushed. Clothes not necessarily fancy, but chosen. A mascara wand had kissed her lashes again. The storm hadn't passed, but it no longer howled.

"Hi," Lavanya said, curling into her usual spot on the couch. "I took my meds today."

"Thank you for showing up," Angelique replied, meaning both the appointment and her life.

The Woman with Two Suns

Lavanya exhaled. "I still feel... foggy. But at least I know it's fog now. Not forever."

"That's all we aim for sometimes," Angelique said. "Clarity, not euphoria."

They sat for a beat.

Lavanya's gaze lingered on a woven wall hanging across the room. "Do you think I'll ever stop fearing the high?"

Angelique nodded slowly. "Recovery in bipolar isn't the absence of extremes. It's learning the language of your thresholds. You've already started."

Lavanya fidgeted with her bracelet. "I journaled about it. I remembered something. My mother used to have these... loud silences. Like you'd walk into the room and *know* she was mad but wouldn't say why. I'd spiral."

"Emotional unpredictability," Angelique said gently. "Especially during your formative years, can create a hypervigilant nervous system. Your brain learned to interpret any change in mood as danger."

Lavanya swallowed. "So the mania felt like escape. And the crash felt like punishment."

Angelique leaned forward slightly. "You're not alone in that narrative. Many people with bipolar disorder experience that push-pull. But you're doing something most don't."

"What's that?"

"You're staying. In the work. In your body. In the grief. That's the real revolution."

Lavanya looked away quickly, blinking. "Don't make me cry. I'll ruin the eyeliner."

They both smiled.

Angelique reached into her drawer again and pulled out a thin booklet — minimalist, with soft violet borders.

"Let's build a plan," she said. "This is a DBT module on *Distress Tolerance*. It won't fix everything, but it'll give you anchors when the tides come."

Lavanya flipped through the first few pages. Ice-diving exercises. TIPP skills. Radical acceptance.

"TFP helped me see how I project abandonment onto the world," she added softly. "Like I'm always waiting for people to ghost me the way my mother emotionally did. Even you, sometimes."

Angelique didn't flinch. "That's valid. And welcome here."

Lavanya gave a sheepish smile. "I almost didn't come today. The grey was so loud this morning."

"But you did."

"Yeah," she whispered. "Because for the first time... I think someone actually sees me."

Angelique closed her notebook.

"No," she said softly. "For the first time... *you* are seeing you."

The silence that followed wasn't hollow. It was sacred.

As the session ended, Lavanya stood up and looked around the room like it had changed.

"Same time next week?" she asked.

Angelique nodded. "Same you. New season."

Lavanya laughed softly, stepping toward the door. But just as her hand touched the knob, she paused.

"Do you think the world's always been like this?" she asked. "So... desensitized? Like people are afraid to feel now."

Angelique didn't answer right away. Instead, she reached up and touched the onyx pendant around her neck — just briefly.

Then she said, "Perhaps the world isn't getting colder. Perhaps it's that souls like yours feel too much... in a time that rewards feeling too little."

The Woman with Two Suns

Lavanya stared for a long moment. Then walked out, leaving a faint shimmer in her place — like she'd been made of light all along.

Sixteen

The Woman Who Couldn't Focus



It was barely ten minutes past the hour, and Angelique was already scanning the corridor for signs of her next client. The morning light slanted across the waiting room couch, catching on the worn leather straps of a student bag tossed carelessly on the armrest.

A blur of energy stumbled through the doorway, talking before the door even shut.

“Hi! I’m so sorry I’m late—actually, no, wait—I’m technically on time if you consider Indian Stretchable Time, right?” She grinned sheepishly, breathless. “I promise I don’t always talk this much. Actually no, I do. Sorry. I’m Himani.”

Angelique smiled warmly. “Come in, Himani.”

The woman plopped down on the couch like she was falling into a beanbag. Her bag fell with a loud thump on the floor. She blinked around the room rapidly, as if noticing everything and nothing at once. Angelique noted the subtle restlessness —

The Woman Who Couldn't Focus

one leg bouncing, fingers fidgeting with the edge of her sleeve, eyes darting to the candle shelf, the antique mirror, the plant in the corner, back to Angelique.

"I wasn't sure what to wear. So I changed. Like three times. And then I got late because I couldn't find my water bottle. Turns out it was in the fridge. I have no idea why."

Angelique didn't interrupt. The rush of words was familiar — like a dam giving way after years of polite restraint.

Himani leaned forward, elbows on knees. "Anyway. I think I might have ADHD. Or I'm just broken. I don't know."

Angelique folded her hands gently. "Let's start with what brought you here today."

Himani tilted her head. "Okay. Uhm... So, I'm doing my master's in social work. Also working part-time with this digital marketing firm. And I'm pretty sure they hate me. I mess up the smallest things. I miss deadlines, forget tasks, take forever to start stuff — and then when I finally do, I can't stop. Like, hyperfocus. I skipped lunch three times last week while writing a single caption."

Angelique raised an eyebrow with a small smile. "That's a very specific example."

"Because I *remember*. Vividly. I even forgot to pee that day."

A beat of silence followed, where Himani's face softened.

"I feel like I'm either too much or not enough," she admitted, quietly now. "Like I'm never the right amount of person."

Angelique let the room exhale with her. "Has anyone ever said that to you before? That you're too much?"

Himani laughed without humor. "My parents. My teachers. My ex. My current boss. My cat, probably."

Angelique tilted her head slightly. "What did you hear as a child when you made mistakes?"

Himani rolled her eyes upward, searching the ceiling for memories. “Mostly: ‘Why can’t you just focus?’ ‘Stop being lazy.’ ‘How many times do I have to repeat myself?’ ‘You’re wasting your potential.’ Stuff like that. I used to be called a ‘bright child with no discipline.’ Which is just a polite way of saying I was chaotic.”

Angelique nodded, noting the shame tucked beneath the self-deprecation. “Do you remember feeling seen?”

Himani blinked at her. “What do you mean?”

“I mean — did anyone ever really *see* the way your brain worked, instead of how it didn’t?”

Himani’s face crumpled a little. “No. I was always the ‘almost’ girl. Almost brilliant. Almost sorted. Almost on time. Almost enough.”

Angelique felt that invisible pulse in the room shift. The moment when a client’s mask begins to slip, not in fear, but in relief.

“You don’t have to perform here, Himani,” she said gently. “You just have to be honest.”

Himani nodded, a little too quickly. “Right. Got it. I’ll try. Wait, no, I *will*—ugh, see, I do this thing where I keep correcting myself out loud because I’m scared, I’ll say the wrong thing. Or say too much.”

“You’re allowed to do both,” Angelique said, her voice steady like a metronome.

Himani smiled at that — a real one, this time. “Thanks.”

* * *

Angelique had noticed it in the first ten minutes—how Himani bounced from one idea to the next like a stone skipping water.

The Woman Who Couldn't Focus

It wasn't aimless. It was musical. But the rhythm, while captivating, was exhausting too—for the speaker more than the listener.

"...and then I realized I hadn't even submitted the proposal. Like it was just sitting there in my Drafts folder, waiting. Like me, honestly," Himani was saying, legs tucked under her on the couch, hands fluttering animatedly as she talked. "Sometimes I open my laptop and I get so overwhelmed I just start watching ASMR videos of soap being cut instead."

Angelique smiled gently. "Do those help ground you?"

"They help... distract me," Himani replied, sheepish. "Grounding would require... grounding. I think I left that ability back in 2009."

Angelique chuckled softly. "What happens in your body when you try to focus and can't?"

Himani blinked. "It's like... everything starts buzzing. My skin feels itchy. I can't sit still. I'll open a tab to reply to an email, but by the time I'm halfway through the sentence, I've remembered I need to update my resume. And then I realize I haven't had lunch. And then I go to the kitchen, see the dishes in the sink, and suddenly I'm spiraling into how I'm probably never going to get my life together."

Angelique nodded. "Do you blame yourself for it?"

"All the time," Himani said quietly. "Everyone says I'm 'so smart' but I just... don't seem to get things done like other people do. Deadlines scare me. I forget things, like important ones. And when someone points it out—especially someone at work—I just crash emotionally. I feel like a stupid little kid."

Angelique leaned in slightly. "Did you ever feel that way growing up?"

There was a beat of silence. Himani's eyes darted to the

corner of the room, a familiar tactic of people who were about to confess something they hadn't told even themselves.

"My mom used to get so angry," she began, voice softer. "She thought I was lazy. 'Why can't you just focus?' she'd shout. I remember once she threw my notebook across the room because I forgot to do one page of homework. I'd spent three hours drawing perfect diagrams. But one page... I just forgot. I always forgot."

Angelique's expression softened, her hands still in her lap. "That must have been really hard for a little girl."

"I used to pretend to be sick to avoid school. Just to avoid the embarrassment of being the last to finish. The messiest notebook. The girl who always lost her pencils." She laughed bitterly. "Turns out that girl just had ADHD."

A moment of silence settled between them. One that didn't need filling.

Angelique reached for her notebook now—not to take notes, but to gently tear out a page. She handed it to Himani along with a pencil.

"Let's make a Quick Fix List," she said. "One that's built for your brain, not against it."

Himani looked at her, unsure.

"Three columns," Angelique explained. "*Things that drain me*, *Things that anchor me*, and *Things I avoid but must face*. No need to be poetic. Just honest."

As Himani scribbled, Angelique spoke softly, almost as if to the air.

"People with ADHD often carry shame instead of tools. They try to fit into a world that wasn't built with them in mind. This is not about 'fixing' you. It's about befriending the way your mind dances."

The Woman Who Couldn't Focus

Himani paused, blinking back sudden tears.

"I'm so tired of trying to be someone else just to be taken seriously," she whispered.

Angelique nodded slowly. "Then maybe it's time to take yourself seriously instead."

* * *

The next session was scheduled the following week.

Himani was already seated when Angelique stepped into the room, fiddling with the silver clasp on her bag as if trying to unlock something inside her own chest.

"Hey," she said with a half-smile that immediately curled into a grimace. "Sorry, I came early. Just... didn't wanna wait outside and accidentally check my emails."

Angelique nodded. "Emails can be emotionally violent."

That made Himani laugh—relieved, maybe, to not have to explain.

Angelique sat down across from her, slipping off her shoes in one smooth motion. "So. How was it, reflecting on the questions I gave you last time?"

Himani exhaled loudly. "Okay. So I *tried* to answer them, but I got distracted. Then I started reorganizing my spice shelf. Then I watched a three-hour YouTube documentary about lost civilizations. *Then* I started again but couldn't remember what I was thinking the first time. So... yeah. Classic me."

Angelique smiled gently. "Did you notice any patterns?"

"I... yeah. I keep starting things and then forgetting I even started them. Like, I'll open my laptop to work on an assignment, and an hour later, I'm reading an article about how octopuses dream."

Angelique's eyes softened. "You sound like a constellation. Scattered but still forming a picture."

Himani blinked. "That's... kind of poetic."

"ADHD brains aren't broken," Angelique said. "They're just tuned into a different frequency. The trick is learning how to dance to your own rhythm without feeling like you have to fit into someone else's tempo."

There was silence for a beat.

Then Himani said, quietly, "I've always felt like I was behind. Like other people got the rulebook and I just... showed up."

Angelique tilted her head. "What do you imagine this rulebook contains?"

"Stuff like—how to remember birthdays. How to not zone out in a meeting. How to finish one thought before starting twelve more. How to not feel like a fucking disaster."

Angelique let the word hang in the air. No need to tidy it up.

"And growing up?" she asked. "What kind of expectations were placed on you?"

"My mom was a teacher. Dad worked for the railways. Both really disciplined. Structure was their love language." She paused. "Which I kept failing at."

"Were you punished for it?"

"Not always directly. Just... compared. My sister was the golden girl. I was the 'creative' one—which is basically code for 'messy and inconsistent.'"

Angelique nodded. "The creative child often ends up being the scapegoat in high-achieving households. There's a mourning that happens there—when you realize your ways of functioning were never seen as valid."

Himani's voice trembled. "Sometimes I wonder if I'll ever be good at life. Like... I'll always be someone who's almost there."

The Woman Who Couldn't Focus

Almost on time. Almost done. Almost okay.”

Angelique didn't respond immediately. Instead, she reached over to the small basket near her chair and took out a deck of grounding cards. She offered one to Himani without looking at it.

“Take one,” she said.

Himani picked a card at random.

It read: *'Forgive the version of you that needed chaos to feel alive.'*

She stared at it for a long time.

“That one hit a little too hard,” she whispered.

Angelique smiled. “That means you're ready.”

“Ready for what?”

“To meet yourself.”

* * *

Angelique handed her a small notepad. “This is called a ‘Momentum Log.’ Every time you finish something—no matter how small—write it down. Brushed your teeth? Log it. Replied to an email? Log it. Ate a meal before 4 PM? Log it. This isn't for tracking productivity. It's for witnessing yourself.”

Himani held it like it might crumble.

“You think I'll actually do it?”

Angelique leaned back. “I think your soul is already tired of being misunderstood. I think you're more capable than you know. And I think you just need a few wins to see that.”

There was silence again, but this time it felt warm. Full.

As Himani got up to leave, she looked over her shoulder.

“Thank you. For seeing through the mess.”

Angelique's voice was soft. “The mess is usually where the art lives.”

21 Mirrors

And as the door clicked shut behind her, Angelique closed her eyes briefly, whispering something only the walls ever heard—

“Another mirror. Pieces stuck together with gold.”

Seventeen

The Boy Who Didn't Know What Was Real



The door opened with a hesitant click, and for a moment, the sunlight from the corridor cast a soft golden halo behind him. He paused before stepping in, eyes scanning the room like it was a temple—or a trap.

Angelique didn't look up just yet. She could feel his presence settle into the room, like incense smoke curling into forgotten corners. The air shifted, thick with something strange... something familiar.

He sat down across from her. Unhurried. Poised. Like he had arrived, not at a clinic, but at a divine appointment.

Angelique finally looked up.

He was striking—not because of his looks, but because of the stillness he carried. The kind that usually belongs to monks or people who've walked too far past the edge of sanity to ever come back untouched.

"Ishaan?" she said gently.

He nodded once. "Yes."

His voice was calm, smooth even—but there was a weight behind it. Like every word he chose had passed through several filters of meaning before reaching her.

"I'm Angelique," she said, offering a small nod. "You can just call me A if that feels easier."

He didn't smile, but something in his posture softened.

"So, Ishaan," she began, tone open and non-invasive, "your sister mentioned you've recently moved back to India?"

"I didn't move back," he said evenly. "I returned."

"Returned?" Angelique echoed.

He leaned forward slightly. "To where I belong. To where I'm needed."

Angelique didn't interrupt. She simply let the silence wrap around them, a space for him to unfurl.

"I was in Boston," he continued. "Doing my Master's in cognitive science. Ironically." A faint smirk.

She caught it. Let it land. "And you left?"

"I didn't leave. I... graduated. Just not in the way they wanted me to."

Angelique tilted her head. "What did that graduation look like?"

He smiled again, this time more deliberate. "I realized that knowledge... Western knowledge... it fragments the soul. Labels, diagnoses, dichotomies. I stopped chasing answers and started listening to questions instead."

"And what did the questions say?"

"That I was never meant to be there," he said. "That my path lies in devotion, not data."

Angelique studied him—not clinically, but energetically.

The Boy Who Didn't Know What Was Real

There was a sharp coherence to his incoherence. The way some lucid dreams make more sense than waking life.

She asked, "What does your day look like now?"

"I wake up at 4," he said proudly. "Chant the Mahamantra. Clean the temple. Prepare for morning darshan. I read the Gita, meditate on the form. I eat only prasadam. My service is my offering."

"And you find peace in this rhythm?"

"Peace is irrelevant," he said. "Purpose is everything."

Angelique let out a slow breath. "Your sister was worried. She said you asked her for money."

He nodded, unfazed. "Yes. Karma tied us together for a reason. She has resources, I have clarity."

"That's an interesting exchange."

He chuckled. "You think I'm here because of her ultimatum. But that's not it."

Angelique raised a brow. "Then why are you here?"

Ishaan paused, long enough for the air to feel reverent.

"Because I saw you," he said.

Her eyes narrowed just a fraction. "Where?"

He tapped his temple. "In a state between sleep and wakefulness. You stood in a forest made of violet light. You were holding something that pulsed with breath, not blood."

Angelique didn't move.

"I've seen many people," he continued, "but only two energies ever matched what I felt in that vision. The first was during my first ayahuasca trip in college. The second... is you."

And then, with the kind of conviction that didn't ask for permission, he looked straight into her eyes and said:

"I'm Krishna. I've returned."

21 Mirrors

* * *

Angelique didn't flinch.

Not when he said it.

Not when he waited to be called delusional.

Not when he paused, half-hoping to be seen through, half-dreading it.

She just tilted her head slightly, as if he'd told her he thought he might be a painter. Or a poet.

"How long have you known?" she asked gently.

"About a year," Ishaan said. "The pieces started aligning after I came back from the States. At first it was... fragments. Random verses from the Gita coming into my head. That deep sense of déjà vu whenever I saw peacocks. I couldn't explain it—until I stopped trying to."

Angelique's pen didn't move. She wasn't writing anything down. Just holding presence.

"I dropped out of my master's," he continued. "Columbia. Data Science. I was one semester in, and it felt like I was... burning alive from the inside."

"Why?"

"Because nothing made sense anymore. I'd be in class and suddenly remember flashes of something ancient. Sometimes I'd dream of battlefields. Blue skin. Flutes. A woman crying in the dark."

"Do you still dream like that?"

"All the time," Ishaan said. "Except now, it's more like... visions. Pieces of a life I've lived before. I don't think it's imagination. It's cellular memory."

Angelique gave a slow nod. "You mentioned ayahwasca earlier. Can you tell me more about that experience?"

The Boy Who Didn't Know What Was Real

His face changed—like the memory came with both reverence and regret.

“It was in Brooklyn. A friend’s friend hosted a ‘ceremony.’ None of us knew what we were doing. Just two facilitators who’d watched too many Vice documentaries. No prep. No intention-setting. Just dim lights and ‘trust the medicine.’”

He laughed bitterly. “I wasn’t ready. I hadn’t eaten. I didn’t even know what I was asking for.”

“What happened?”

“I saw her,” he said, quietly. “Not in the room. Not physically. But... I saw *her*. This tall woman made of vines and fire and something ancient. And she was crying for the world. Crying for people who forgot who they were. I wanted to help her.”

His voice cracked.

“I think that’s when something shifted in me. I couldn’t go back to school. Couldn’t sit in cafés with my laptop like I used to. I needed to *remember*.”

Angelique’s expression didn’t change, but her energy did. A subtle pulse in the room. A shift in air.

“And did you?” she asked softly. “Remember?”

“I remembered enough to walk away from everything that didn’t feel real. My degree. My apartment. That whole life felt like a rented costume. I wanted India. I wanted temples. Bhajans. Dust. Something raw.”

Angelique finally picked up her pen. Wrote down a single word: **rupture**.

“Do you ever doubt what you believe?” she asked.

He looked up sharply. “Why would I?”

“Because real identity is elastic,” she said. “Even divinity is porous.”

That made him pause.

"I know people think I'm crazy," he said, softer now. "My sister thinks I'm having some kind of episode. But the more I try to explain, the more I sound... well, exactly like someone who needs help."

"And do you?"

Ishaan blinked.

"Need help?" he repeated.

Angelique nodded.

He was quiet for a long time.

Then finally, "I don't know. Maybe. But not because I think I'm Krishna. I think I need help *because I can't be normal anymore.*"

Angelique let the silence hold that line gently.

Not to fix it. Not to question it.

But to give it space to breathe.

* * *

"I wasn't always like this," Ishaan said, his eyes distant. "Back in high school, I was the golden boy. Valedictorian. Science Olympiad. Everyone expected me to build something. Become someone."

Angelique leaned in slightly—not with her body, but her energy.

"So when did that begin to change?"

He looked away. "It was gradual. But if I'm honest... maybe it started when my grandfather died. He used to say I had 'an old soul.' Taught me Sanskrit shlokas before I even knew what they meant. I think losing him cracked something open."

Angelique wrote a single word: **rupture**, and beneath it: **longing**.

The Boy Who Didn't Know What Was Real

"I kept trying to make the world fit," Ishaan continued. "Tried coding, calculus, career fairs. But the more I tried, the more alien it felt. Like I was watching myself from the outside. Like I'd been placed in the wrong timeline."

He looked up at Angelique suddenly. "Do you believe in that? Wrong timelines?"

Angelique's voice was like velvet wrapped around thunder. "I believe the soul remembers things the mind forgets. And sometimes... when those memories get loud, they echo through our identity."

Ishaan held her gaze. For a moment too long.

"I've met you before," he said.

Angelique didn't move. Just the faintest upward curve of her mouth.

"I mean—not like this. But when I drank the brew... the ayahuasca. In that dream... or vision, or whatever you want to call it... there was a woman."

A pause.

"You weren't vines or fire then," he added. "You were light. And grief. And the earth. You didn't say anything. You just *looked* at me. Like you are now."

Something trembled in the air.

Angelique placed her pen down.

"What did that version of me make you feel?"

Ishaan swallowed. "Safe. Seen. But also like... like I couldn't hide."

Another silence bloomed between them—this one fertile.

"You said earlier you weren't sure if you need help," Angelique finally said. "But I think a part of you came here hoping I'd say something that would make all of this *make sense*."

He nodded slowly.

"Thing is," she continued, "I won't tell you you're not Krishna. I also won't tell you that you are. What I *can* offer... is a space where we find out who Ishaan is *beneath* the belief. Not to erase it. But to uncover what's underneath."

He blinked hard. "What if I don't like what I find?"

She tilted her head. "What if what you find... finally likes *you*?"

That hit something deep.

Tears shimmered but didn't fall.

Angelique leaned back. "For this week, no big assignments. Just one thing. Whenever you feel most convinced that you're him—that you are Krishna—pause. Write down *what* was happening. The triggers. The emotions. The need. We're not here to disprove your truth. Just to explore the *why* underneath it."

Ishaan nodded, a little dazed.

As he rose to leave, he looked back at her once.

"You never asked me what I saw in that first ayahuasca vision. The *last* image before I woke up."

"I didn't," Angelique said softly.

He hesitated. "It was a cracked mirror. Floating in the sky. And in it... I saw a little boy, holding a broken flute. Crying, but smiling."

Angelique's expression didn't change. But her hand went to the black onyx pendant at her throat.

"I'll see you next week, Ishaan."

He nodded, still unsure whether this had been therapy... or a remembering.

Eighteen

The Dancer Made of Ashes



The screen blinked twice before settling into view — a dim room, a tuft of blonde hair tucked behind one ear, eyes half-lidded, drifting in and out of presence. Angelique adjusted the earbuds in her ears and leaned back ever so slightly.

The glow of her laptop framed her face in silver.

She never took clients online unless absolutely necessary. But this one — this one came as a favor to someone she couldn't say no to. Ishaan's sister, Eesha, had reached out through an unexpectedly heartfelt voice note.

"I have a friend in New York. She's not doing well. Used to be a ballerina — like, prodigy-level. Now she barely gets out of bed. She trusts me... barely. But if anyone can reach her, I think you can."

Angelique had hesitated for exactly two breaths before replying, *"Send her the link. Let her decide."*

The woman on-screen finally blinked and gave a lopsided smile. "Soo... you're the shrink." Her words had that stretched

molasses quality. “God, you’re so... calm. That’s... fuckin’ wild.”

Angelique smiled, gentle but clear. “And you’re Lena?”

She gave a sluggish nod. “Eesha says you’re... like, not a regular therapist. That you’re into... dreams? Weird shit?” Her eyes squinted, vaguely amused.

Angelique didn’t flinch. “Let’s say I meet people where they are.”

Lena laughed — a dry, breathy sound that didn’t quite reach her eyes. “I’m nowhere, then.”

There was silence for a moment. Lena reached for something off-screen — her hand shaky — and took a sip. Water? Vodka? Angelique didn’t ask.

“I don’t usually do this,” Lena murmured, voice quieter now. “I mean, therapy. Or... talking. Or... life.”

“Then thank you,” Angelique said sincerely. “For showing up. That counts for more than most people realize.”

Lena shrugged, but her lips twitched.

“Tell me, Lena... why now?”

The dancer exhaled long and slow. “Because... my body’s starting to forget how to dance. My fingers don’t listen anymore. I get... locked. Like stone. Like a corpse in pointed shoes.”

She chuckled, bitter. “So I pop another pill. Then another. And the pain — emotional, physical, all of it — it turns into this... floaty hum. I become... background noise.”

Her head tilted. “You ever felt that? Like your soul’s buffering?”

Angelique didn’t answer. Her silence was the kind that invited.

Lena continued, words slurring at the edges. “I was meant

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to be... light. Movement. Fuckin' poetry in motion, right? But now I'm just... ash in a leotard. Ash in leggings. Ash in... whatever."

She rubbed her temples. "I didn't even wanna do this call. But 'Lena owes Eesha', right? That's always been the thing."

Angelique watched her carefully — not just the words, but the air between them.

"It's okay if you don't want to talk about it all at once," she said, voice as steady as a lighthouse beam. "Maybe we can begin with what hurts the least."

Lena blinked, and something flickered in her — like a dancer recognizing a familiar rhythm in a song long forgotten.

"I don't know what hurts the least," she whispered.

"Then we begin with the truth: You don't know. That's enough."

And just like that, the call — though pixelated, distorted, half-lit — felt more real than most things Lena had known in months.

* * *

The screen froze briefly as Lena shifted, her face momentarily caught in mid-blink. When it returned, she was curled up on her couch, a grey hoodie swallowing her frame.

"So," she mumbled, "you wanna hear the sob story now?"

Angelique didn't move. "Only if you want to tell it."

Lena let out a dry laugh. "What do people usually say? Childhood crap? Bad ex? Injured my ankle? Add some daddy issues and bam! - full house?"

"Sometimes," Angelique replied softly, "but sometimes it's subtler. A slow fading. Like fog creeping into a field no one

remembered existed.”

Lena looked away. “I started dancing when I was three. Ballet. My mom was a costume designer, and I was her little doll. Perfect buns, pink tights, the whole thing.”

She rubbed her face. “I was good. Too good. They said I had the kind of body choreographers dream of. Long lines. Elastic spine. I got scholarships. I skipped parties. Said no to prom. Just... danced. And for a while, that was enough.”

Angelique didn’t interrupt. She simply breathed, deeply and evenly, anchoring the space.

Lena swallowed. “Then came... the break. You know? That thing. My hip just... snapped mid-rehearsal. It was quiet — like a branch breaking under snow. The pain was instant. But what hurt more was the silence in the studio. No one ran to help. Just... slow head turns.”

She looked straight into the camera. “They replaced me in two days.”

Angelique’s voice, when it came, was gentle. “What did that do to you?”

Lena shrugged, but her jaw tightened. “I realized I wasn’t a person. Just a vessel. Useful until broken.”

She exhaled harshly through her nose. “That’s when the pills started. Painkillers at first. Then... more.”

There was a pause. Then, unexpectedly, her voice broke.

“Sometimes... I still feel phantom pain. Not in the hip. In my heart. Like some part of me’s still on that stage, waiting for the music to come back.”

Angelique’s voice was lower now, closer, as though she had leaned into the screen. “And when you dance in your dreams?”

Lena blinked. “How’d you—?”

Angelique smiled faintly. “Just a hunch.”

The Dancer Made of Ashes

Lena softened — the first real shift in her entire posture. “In my dreams, I don’t need technique. I just move. It’s wild. Animal-like. But free. My body glows. There’s light under my skin. And... sometimes, I think something — someone — dances with me.”

Angelique leaned back, fingertips brushing the base of her onyx pendant. “Tell me more.”

Lena hesitated. “It’s a woman. She never speaks. But I feel her. Ancient energy. Like a forest that’s watched centuries pass. She never judges me. Only... mirrors.”

Angelique’s eyes closed briefly. The air in her room changed.

“What if,” she said slowly, “she’s not a dream, Lena?”

The dancer’s eyes widened just a fraction. “You think I’m losing it?”

“I think,” Angelique said, “you’ve always known magic. You just used to call it choreography.”

A silence settled between them, ripe with old truth.

* * *

Lena’s knee bounced restlessly under the table. She looked more alert now — the sluggish haze had lifted a little, but the tension was louder. Like a room that’s been cleaned too fast and still smells like smoke.

“I don’t want to be like this,” she said. “But I don’t know how to be anything else.”

Angelique nodded slowly. “The pills helped you survive. That’s what they do. But they can’t show you who you are.”

Lena scoffed. “Who I am? A disappointment. That’s all I’ve ever been once I stopped performing.”

Angelique leaned forward, steady and grounded. “You are not the roles you once played, Lena. You’re not the applause or the relapse. You are what remains when the curtain falls. And I think... what remains is still whole.”

Lena’s lips parted, but no words came.

“I’d like us to explore something called *Somatic Experiencing*,” Angelique continued. “It helps the body release trauma stored in the nervous system. You’ve been in survival mode for so long, it might feel strange to be still. But your body remembers how to feel safe. We just need to teach it again.”

Lena nodded faintly.

“I’m also going to recommend a holistic rehab center here in India. They integrate movement therapy, trauma work, and guided detox. Nothing forceful. Just... a reset. And I’ll refer you to a physician I trust — someone who understands addiction as a coping strategy, not a moral failure. He’ll help with the cravings, the fatigue, even the hormonal crashes.”

Lena exhaled as if someone had just lifted a weight off her spine. “You’re... not judging me.”

Angelique smiled. “No. I’m witnessing you.”

That’s when Lena’s voice trembled. “My parents haven’t called in weeks. Last time, my mom said she didn’t recognize me anymore. And I guess... I don’t either.”

The words sat heavy between them.

Angelique’s tone was velvet. “You are still you, Lena. Buried under the ash, yes. But not gone. You’ve danced with the fire and survived. And now, the body will lead you back.”

Lena nodded, tears escaping silently. “What if I mess up again?”

“Then you’ll come back. And we’ll try again.”

A long pause.

The Dancer Made of Ashes

"I had a dream last night," Lena whispered. "I was on stage. No lights. No audience. Just that woman again... the one from before. She held out her hand this time. Didn't say a word. But I... I followed."

Angelique's face remained unreadable, but something shimmered in her eyes. A quiet, ancient knowing.

"Follow her," she said. "She may be the part of you that never broke."

Nineteen

The Boy Who Forgot to Care



The silence in Angelique's office felt tighter than usual. The antique clock ticked with unusual sharpness, as if it, too, was holding its breath.

"I don't know if I'm imagining it, or if it's really... happening," the mother whispered.

Across from her, a boy sat with the posture of someone far older than seventeen. Clean, composed, hair gelled into submission. His school blazer rested folded on his lap. He was smiling — not warmly, but in a way that made Angelique feel like she was the one being studied.

"He's... polite," the mother continued, fidgeting with her rings. "Good grades. No trouble at school. Teachers say he's respectful, helpful even."

"But?"

She swallowed. "Last month, our neighbor's cat went missing. Two weeks later, I found its collar buried in the garden. Under

The Boy Who Forgot to Care

the soil. Next to a bird cage... completely empty. And the weird part is — I'd never seen that birdcage before. When I asked him, he said *he* hadn't either. And smiled. Just like that."

Angelique turned her gaze to the boy. He blinked at her. Calm. Amused.

"What's your name?" she asked softly.

"Vihaan."

"And how do you feel about being here, Vihaan?"

"I'm not the one who thinks I need help," he said with a shrug, then glanced at his mother. "She does."

Angelique let that hang in the air. The boy's voice was crisp. Emotionally neutral. There was no hostility. No real irritation either. Just... an absence of something. Something vital.

The mother leaned forward. "He used to be different, you know. He was *sweet*. Not expressive maybe, but he used to cry when his goldfish died. He laughed when I tickled him. But since the divorce... it's like he's become a blank wall. Or worse, he's started taking pleasure in—" She stopped, voice catching. "In scaring his sister."

Vihaan looked at her now. His smile widened slightly. "She scares easily. It's not my fault."

Angelique's fingers traced the rim of her teacup. She felt a faint hum in her solar plexus. Something rare. Not darkness... but *detachment*.

"And what happened during the divorce, Vihaan?" she asked, gently.

He shrugged. "Nothing. Dad left. Mom cried a lot. My sister was annoying."

"Did it make you angry?"

He paused, as if genuinely trying to consider the question. "No. It just made things quieter."

21 Mirrors

Angelique nodded slowly. Her gaze flicked to the mirror across the room. Faintly, it shimmered.

“He’s... cold,” the mother murmured, voice barely audible. “I can’t explain it. I *want* to connect with him. But I don’t think he wants anything from me. Not even love.”

Angelique shifted her gaze back to the boy. “Is that true, Vihaan? Do you feel like something’s missing... or do you feel complete as you are?”

He stared at her for a long moment, then leaned forward, resting his chin on his hand. “I think everyone else is too emotional. I like being like this. It makes things... clearer.”

There it was again — the calm detachment. But behind it, Angelique sensed a flicker. Not remorse. Not sadness.

But curiosity.

As the mother covered her face in quiet defeat, Angelique didn’t reach for her pendant this time. She didn’t need to.

This mirror was different.

This one reflected silence.

Not of peace — but of absence.

* * *

The mother was asked to step outside.

Not for safety.

For clarity.

Angelique watched Vihaan settle deeper into the chair, crossing one leg over the other like a seasoned executive. His fingers tapped a rhythm on the armrest — four taps, pause, three taps, pause, repeat.

“Why the pattern?” she asked, casually.

He glanced down. “It calms me. Like counting sheep for

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normal people.”

She smiled gently. “And you don’t consider yourself normal?”

“No.”

He didn’t blink.

There was no bravado in his voice. No self-pity. Just the calm acknowledgment of an observable fact.

Angelique leaned back. “Do you ever feel guilty?”

“For what?”

“Hurting someone. Intentionally or not.”

Vihaan tilted his head, eyes narrowing — not in confusion, but in curiosity. “Guilt is useless. It doesn’t undo anything. It’s just... noise.”

“And empathy?”

A pause. His fingers stilled.

“That’s... harder,” he said. “Sometimes, I *copy* what I think I’m supposed to feel. I’ll even say the right thing. But it’s like watching someone else do it. Like I’m imitating a version of me that’s more likable.”

Angelique let the silence stretch.

He didn’t seem uncomfortable in it. He seemed to *enjoy* it — the space it gave him to dissect her face, her body language, her breath.

“I read people well,” he said, suddenly. “I can tell when they’re lying. Or faking emotions. Or playing the victim.”

“Do you think your mother plays the victim?”

“No.”

He leaned forward, voice low. “I think she’s weak. Which is worse.”

The temperature in the room dropped a notch. Not physically — energetically.

“Does it bother you? That she’s weak?”

"I don't *need* her," he replied. "But she needs me to need her. That's the problem."

Angelique studied him. The precision of his speech. The subtle, calculating coldness. She wasn't staring into the eyes of a villain. She was looking at a brilliant mind... one that had never been taught how to feel.

"How do you feel about your sister?"

A pause again. Longer this time.

"She cries too much," he said finally. "I wanted to see how far I could push it."

"Why?"

He looked her dead in the eyes. "Because I could."

There it was. The fracture line.

Not hate. Not pleasure.

Just power.

Angelique didn't flinch. "What would happen, Vihaan, if one day... someone did the same to you?"

His lips curled into a faint smile. "I'd admire them."

A beat passed.

Then two.

"Would you feel afraid?" she asked softly.

Vihaan hesitated — just a blink, barely perceptible.

"No," he said. But something shifted in his posture. A flicker in his gaze. As if a wire deep inside had twitched.

Angelique noticed. She always did.

"And what would you do to someone who made you feel something real?"

He looked at her, that too-old-for-seventeen stillness returning.

"I'd either become them... or destroy them."

Her breath caught, just a fraction.

The Boy Who Forgot to Care

And still — she didn't reach for her pendant. Not this time. This mirror... would not be tamed by touch.

* * *

Angelique waited until Vihaan left the room to use the wash-room. He never asked — just stood up mid-session, as if excusing himself from a boring board meeting.

On his chair, his sketchbook lay half-open. Tempting. Like a forbidden chapter.

She exhaled quietly, picked it up.

The first page was abstract. Lines and symbols drawn with manic precision — like a mind trying to keep order in chaos.

The next one, though, was unmistakable.

A girl. Young. Hair plastered to her cheeks. Mouth open in a scream — no sound.

Angelique turned another page. The girl again, but this time... still. Eyes vacant. Limbs twisted. Flowers growing from her mouth.

Not fantasy. A ritual.

She heard the door click behind her and set the book down just in time.

Vihaan sat back down like nothing had happened.

"You like art?" he asked.

"I like insight," she replied.

"Then you must've loved the one with the bleeding tree."

She didn't respond.

Instead, she said, "Do you remember the last time someone made you feel unsafe?"

Vihaan blinked, surprised.

"No one's ever made me feel unsafe. Not since I was five,

anyway.”

“What happened then?”

He stared at her, but didn’t answer.

Which was an answer.

Angelique opened her folder. “We’ll begin something new next week — it’s called *moral reasoning therapy*. We’ll look at scenarios and explore not just *what* people do... but *why* they choose it.”

He scoffed. “Another game?”

“No,” she said calmly. “This one changes brains. And lives.”

He drummed his fingers again — four taps, pause, three taps, pause.

“Why bother?” he muttered. “You think reading a few fake stories will make me ‘good’?”

She shook her head. “I don’t believe in ‘good.’ I believe in *choices*. And learning how to widen the gap between impulse and action.”

Stillness.

“You’ll also start *cognitive behavioral work*. Just five minutes a day. We’ll practice labeling thoughts instead of reacting to them. And we’ll try *identifying consequences* — not because I expect you to care about them, but because awareness matters.”

He didn’t nod. But he didn’t fight it either.

“And,” she added, “you’ll keep sketching.”

He looked at her sharply. “Why?”

“Because it’s the one place you’re honest.”

A beat.

“You’re not scared of me,” he said, tilting his head.

“No,” she replied softly. “But I care what becomes of you.”

That flicker again. The one that might have been... almost... pain.

The Boy Who Forgot to Care

* * *

Angelique glanced at the clock: 5:03 PM.

Vihaan was never late.

His sessions began like clockwork. He'd enter silently, drop his bag on the chair, flip open his sketchbook, and wait. Wordless. Controlled.

But today... nothing.

She glanced at the file she'd prepped. A new activity. A prompt.

"Draw the moment you first realized the world wasn't safe."

She sighed, sipped her now-lukewarm tea, and reached for a book.

The phone rang.

She knew the number.

"Mrs. Mehta," she said, already bracing.

The woman's voice was dry. Fragile.

"Vihaan won't be coming in for therapy today."

Angelique straightened. "Is he alright?"

A long pause. Too long.

"He's not home yet. His bag's missing. So is his sketchbook."

Angelique's breath slowed.

"It's been a weird day for us," the mother continued, trying to sound composed. "A girl's body was found in the garden behind our building."

No emotion. Just data.

"My daughter... she opened the door. The cops were asking around if anyone had seen the girl before."

Another pause.

"So yeah. He won't be coming in today."

Click.

21 Mirrors

Angelique lowered the phone.

She didn't move.

Didn't speak.

Just... sat there, watching the shadows on the floor lengthen
— inching slowly toward the mirror on the far wall.

Some mirrors reflect light.

Others crack.

And some...

are born shattered.

Twenty

The Girl Who Lived in a Dream



The screen flickered once before settling into focus.

Zaria appeared — ring light glow bouncing off her cheekbones, a silk bonnet wrapped snugly around her curls. Her eyes, large and glistening with excitement, darted between the screen and something just beyond it. Maybe a note she'd scribbled. Or a hope she didn't want to forget to mention.

"Hey Angelique!"

She waved with a little too much energy. Her voice had a musicality to it — fast, lilting, slightly performative.

Angelique smiled. "Hey Zaria. Looks like you've been waiting for this one."

Zaria laughed. "Girl, you have *no idea*. The signs today? Wild. Okay, so listen — I saw 111, 222, 999 — all of 'em. Back to back. Then this YouTube reader, she pulled the *exact same cards* I got in my personal reading last night. The Tower, the Lovers, and the Eight of Cups. Again."

Angelique tilted her head. “And what did that mean to you?”

“That I’m about to have a reunion. With him.”

Her screen dimmed slightly as she leaned forward, eyes shining with devotion. “It’s coming. I can *feel* it. Spirit’s been making it real clear this time. He’s my twin flame. He’s just... resisting.”

Angelique let the silence cradle the moment before responding.

“What makes you believe he’s your twin flame, Zaria?”

Zaria blinked. For a second, the role of spiritual messenger slipped, and she was just... a girl in love.

“Because I’ve *never* felt this way before. It’s electric. Insane. Painful but magnetic. Like, the universe literally shut every other door on purpose so I’d choose *him*. Every reading, every dream, even the timing of when we met — it’s all *too aligned* to be a coincidence.”

Angelique nodded. “That sounds like a very intense connection.”

“It is! Even the fights — they’re like... karmic. Like, soul-level triggers, you know? He pushes every single one of my buttons, but it’s so I grow. I know it sounds toxic, but that’s what twin flames *do*. They hurt you so you can heal.”

A quiet inhale.

Angelique didn’t challenge it. Not yet.

Instead, she asked, “When was the last time you heard from him?”

Zaria’s gaze shifted. The screen caught the moment her mask slipped.

“Four months ago. But he watches my stories. And I know his new girl is just... a karmic. A placeholder. I get dreams of him almost every night. And when I do, I wake up with this ache

The Girl Who Lived in a Dream

in my chest, like something was torn out. I swear sometimes I can feel him touching me — like he's astral projecting or something."

Angelique folded her hands. "And what do you feel during the day, when the dreams fade?"

Zaria paused. Looked down.

"Lonely," she admitted. "But like... chosen lonely. Like this is all part of the divine plan."

Angelique's voice remained warm, but steady.

"And when was the last time you felt joy... that didn't come from a reading, or a hope about him?"

Zaria blinked again.

Longer, slower.

The silence this time wasn't mystical. It was confronting.

"I don't know," she whispered.

The mirror behind Angelique shimmered subtly in the candlelight — almost like something watching gently from beyond the veil.

Angelique leaned in.

"Zaria... what if the Universe isn't testing your faith in him... but inviting you to have faith in yourself? What if this ache you feel isn't love... but your inner child, trying to wake you from the dream?"

Zaria's bottom lip trembled. But she didn't cry. Not yet.

She just stared — as if someone had just cracked open a truth she had almost buried inside her own breath.

* * *

"I think I've always had this," Zaria said, fingers tracing the edge of her mug. "This thing where I make people bigger than

they are. Like I paint them with some kind of magic, and then I wait for them to live up to it.”

Angelique nodded gently.

“That sounds lonely.”

Zaria smiled sadly. “It is. And addictive.”

The pause between them wasn’t awkward — it was sacred. A moment of permission.

“I used to do this in college too,” she continued. “There was this guy who barely spoke to me, but I made a whole relationship in my head. Like a movie. I could feel him looking at me when he wasn’t. I could hear conversations that never happened. I even wrote poems about us... and we never went on a single date.”

Angelique didn’t look away. “That sounds painful. What did you feel when the fantasy cracked?”

Zaria exhaled. “Embarrassment. But also grief. Like I’d lost something *real*. And I *knew* it wasn’t... but it felt like it.”

“That’s the trap of limerence,” Angelique said softly. “The bond forms not between two people — but between you and your *own mind’s version* of them. It’s not love. It’s longing masquerading as fate.”

Zaria looked up. Her voice barely above a whisper. “Why do I do this?”

“Because it fills a hole,” Angelique said. “One that formed long before he entered the picture.”

Zaria’s shoulders slumped.

“Childhood?”

Angelique gave a small, sad smile. “You tell me.”

Zaria was quiet for a long time.

Then — “My dad was in and out. My mom... she worked three jobs. I was mostly with my grandma. She loved me, but

The Girl Who Lived in a Dream

she also scared me sometimes. She'd talk about demons and hexes, and made me sleep with a Bible under my pillow. There was love — but it was laced with fear. Unpredictable. I guess I just started looking for something *bigger* than me to hold on to. God. Love. Destiny."

Angelique's voice softened. "And when you met this man..."

Zaria finished the sentence: "It felt like all of that wrapped in one."

Angelique let that land.

"Zaria... twin flames or not — you deserve a love that doesn't confuse you. That doesn't make you beg spirit for signs because the human in front of you won't just show up."

Zaria's throat tightened. "What if I can't stop waiting for him?"

Angelique smiled. "Then we'll make the waiting sacred."

Zaria blinked, unsure what she meant.

"We'll give the waiting a purpose. We'll turn it into a devotion — not to him, but to the parts of you that still believe in rescue. We'll meet every abandoned version of you. And then we'll build you a life so full, so breathtaking... that even the *idea* of waiting starts to feel like a disservice."

Zaria breathed out — like she'd been underwater.

"Okay," she said. "Okay. I want that."

* * *

The call timer hovers just above the 55-minute mark. Zaria's screen flickers for a second — not from bad Wi-Fi, but as if something subtle had shifted in the frequency of the room.

Angelique leaned forward slightly, the light from her candle casting a golden glow on her face.

“Zaria... I want to try something with you before we wrap up.”

Zaria nodded, her eyes tired but soft.

“I want you to write a letter tonight. But not to him.”

Zaria tilted her head.

Angelique continued:

“Write a letter to the version of you who still believes that being chosen by him would finally mean something about *you*. That version who waits by the phone, checks the tarot spreads, believes every love song is a sign.”

Zaria looked down, already blinking back emotion.

“And then,” Angelique said, “I want you to end that letter with a promise — that you’ll no longer abandon her to the fantasy.”

Silence.

Zaria whispered, “What if I don’t know how to stop?”

Angelique’s voice was soft but unwavering.

“Then let’s start by knowing it’s not your fault. Limerence isn’t madness. It’s your mind’s way of coping with emptiness. It’s hope, overdosed.”

Zaria let out a shaky laugh.

Angelique smiled gently. “We’ll wean you off the fantasy. Not by shame. Not by force. But by slowly building a life that feels real enough, warm enough... that the dream begins to pale in comparison.”

Zaria nodded.

And then Angelique added — almost like a benediction:

“You are not delusional for loving deeply. You are not broken for craving intensity. It just means your soul remembers a time when love *was* divine... and you’re homesick for it.”

Zaria blinked.

And blinked again.

The Girl Who Lived in a Dream

“...Thank you,” she said, her voice the smallest it had been all session. “I think this was the first time someone didn’t laugh at me for all this.”

Angelique simply smiled.

“Most people live asleep, Zaria. You? You just dreamed too vividly.”

The call ended.

She exhaled, feeling the echo of Zaria’s longing still vibrating in the air.

And with a softness that could only come from having survived it herself, she said —

“Sometimes, it’s not love.”

“It’s just a wound... dressed up like destiny.”

Twenty-One

The Girl Who Stayed



That morning, Angelique woke before the sun.

Not with dread. Not with peace.

But with a hollowed-out stillness, the kind that arrived when a soul knew — without evidence — that something irreversible was about to be spoken into the world.

She hadn't slept much the night before. The dream had returned.

But this time, it stayed longer.

In the dream, she had been standing on the edge of a nameless river. Not crossing it. Not drowning. Just... watching.

From across the current, she saw a girl — mid-thirties perhaps, eyes older than her face, holding a kite with no wind to lift it.

Around her, ghost-memories flickered like projections on a broken reel:

A blood-soaked bedsheet that wouldn't come clean.

The Girl Who Stayed

A father's silence so sharp it split her laughter down the middle.

A gold medal pushed into the back of a drawer because her brother had cried when he didn't get one.

The scent of her mother's perfume — jasmine and detachment.

A child's drawing torn in half. Not out of anger, but obedience.

In the dream, the girl didn't cry.

Instead, she dug her heels into the soil as if to say — *I'll stay. Even if it kills me.*

Angelique had awoken with her hand on her heart, as if trying to press the vision back into herself.

And now, as she sat in her office, the antique mirror shimmered faintly in the corner — the way it always did when a soul on the brink of healing was about to arrive.

The session was scheduled for 10:00 AM. It was already 10:08.

She didn't check the time again. She never did, when she knew they were coming.

At 10:11, the chime of the outer door finally rang. A soft knock followed.

Angelique rose, smoothed the folds of her long cardigan, and opened the door.

Her client stepped in — tall, composed, but fraying at the edges. Grief lived in her spine, in the way her shoulders slouched not from posture but from carrying too much for too long.

She offered a polite, practiced smile. "Sorry I'm late. Auto bailed midway. Had to walk."

Angelique nodded, her voice gentle. "You came. That's what

matters.”

The woman smiled faintly and sat down, already slipping into the comfort of the chair she’d grown to trust.

Today’s session had a different air. Unspoken. Thicker.

The kind of weight that meant something long-buried was clawing its way to the surface.

Angelique leaned in slightly.

“What would you like to begin with?”

The woman’s eyes found the mirror across the room. Not with interest. But with knowing.

“I think I’m ready to talk about... *him*.”

A pause.

“My father.”

The name was an exhale. Not of relief. But of defeat.

And just like that, the mirror shimmered again — catching the light at an impossible angle.

Angelique didn’t blink.

She was ready.

* * *

She didn’t cry.

Not right away.

Instead, she picked at the loose thread on her sleeve — one of the thousand small self-soothing rituals she’d perfected in place of tears.

Angelique watched her silently, the space between them humming with permission.

“My dad never hit me,” she began. “Which... you’d think is a good thing. But I used to wish he had.”

Angelique tilted her head slightly. “Why?”

The Girl Who Stayed

“Because then it would’ve made sense. His anger. His coldness. The way he made me feel like a constant disappointment. If he’d hit me, I could’ve at least *proven* something happened. But silence? Silence doesn’t bruise.”

Her voice trembled — not from emotion, but from exhaustion. From the weight of holding a truth too intangible to mourn.

“And when he died,” she continued, “I didn’t feel grief. Not the normal kind. I felt... robbed. Of closure. Of answers. Of the chance to scream *Why didn’t you fucking love me?* to his face.”

Angelique let her speak. Let her unravel.

Because grief like this doesn’t respond to platitudes.

It needs a place to be *witnessed*.

“I was the ‘mature one,’” she said. “The overachiever. The peacemaker. The kid who fixed the lightbulbs when mom cried in the kitchen. Who kept her grades up so the house wouldn’t feel like it was falling apart. Who didn’t win awards too publicly because her brother felt ‘left behind.’”

A beat.

“I dimmed every part of me so that nobody else would feel uncomfortable.”

Angelique’s eyes softened. “And what did that do to the parts you dimmed?”

The woman looked up — for the first time, truly meeting her gaze.

“They died. Slowly. Quietly. Like little funerals in my chest I never told anyone about.”

Silence.

She inhaled sharply. “And then college happened. And I met someone. And for once... I wasn’t invisible. I felt seen. Safe.”

Her jaw clenched.

"We were stupid. We didn't have money. I missed my period and we both panicked. There was no one I could tell. Not my mom. Not my friends. And definitely not *him*. He ran the minute I said the word 'pregnant.'"

Angelique already knew this. It had come up in a past session — in passing. Never fully voiced. Until now.

"I had to get the abortion alone. I remember the ceiling more than I remember the pain. It had cracks shaped like lightning. I stared at it while the nurse held my hand and told me I was brave."

She scoffed.

"I wasn't brave. I was just... alone."

Her hand moved instinctively to her stomach.

"I think about it more often than I admit. Not just the baby. But the version of me who sat in that clinic. She still lives inside me. Frozen."

Angelique didn't speak.

Because this — this was the moment.

"I want to forgive my father," she said, finally. "But I don't know how to forgive someone who made me feel like my grief was always... too loud. Too much."

A single tear broke free then. Not from her eyes. From her chest.

Angelique leaned in. "You don't need to forgive him to heal. You just need to choose yourself now. Every version of you that stayed quiet. Every girl you were forced to abandon to survive."

She nodded slowly. "I think I'm ready."

Angelique opened her drawer and pulled out a folded sheet of handmade paper.

The Girl Who Stayed

“Write her a letter. The girl in the clinic. The girl who never got to cry after the funeral. The girl who turned down her own light so others wouldn’t trip over the brightness.”

The woman held the page like it might shatter.

“And then?” she asked softly.

“Then we do the ceremony.”

A pause.

Angelique smiled gently. “You’ll know what I mean when we get there.”

* * *

The letter was folded thrice.

Edges uneven. Ink smudged. A single teardrop had bloomed into the corner of the page like a watermark no one else would notice — but Angelique did.

They sat by the window this time. Not on the couch. Not across from each other like therapist and client. But side by side. Like two women sharing a vigil.

“I don’t want to read it out loud,” she whispered.

“You don’t have to.”

She stared out the window. A crow landed on the ledge outside. Jet black. Watching.

Angelique lit a single candle and placed it between them.

“No rituals, no pressure,” she said. “Just acknowledgment. That’s all grief ever wanted.”

A few minutes passed like hours.

Then, quietly, the woman unfolded the letter and began to tear it. One slow rip at a time. Like molting.

“Why does this feel like I’m killing her?” she asked, her voice cracking.

21 Mirrors

Angelique's voice was the hush of a tide returning to shore.

"You're not killing her. You're letting her go. She stayed too long, carrying pain that wasn't hers. That isn't death. That's release."

She paused.

"And sometimes... the deepest grief isn't for the people we lost. It's for the *parts of ourselves* that we never got to meet."

The woman's breath shook, but this time she let it. She didn't silence the tremor. She let the ache pass through her like rain through an open window.

When the final shred was gone, she placed it in the flame. Watched it curl and wither into ash.

A silence followed.

Not the heavy kind.

The kind that comes when something has *lifted*.

"Do you think she knows?" the woman asked softly. "The girl I used to be?"

Angelique smiled.

"She does now."

They didn't hug. They didn't need to.

But when the woman stood to leave, she touched Angelique's hand briefly. A gesture that said more than words ever could.

The door clicked shut behind her.

And the room exhaled.

The session was over.

* * *

Epilogue



The woman had left.

The grief had not.

Angelique sat still, as if the moment itself were waiting for her to move first.

But she didn't.

Instead, she reached for the empty cup beside her — lifted it halfway — then paused, her eyes catching something.

The mirror across the room.

For a moment, it didn't reflect her at all.

Only light.

And then — a flicker.

A dozen eyes.

A hundred hands.

A single heartbeat.

She didn't blink.

Didn't smile.

Didn't speak.

Only watched as the mirror shimmered... then stilled.

And in that stillness, the veil closed.

Softly.

21 Mirrors

Completely.

Then, quietly — she stood.

Not as a therapist.

Not as a guide.

Not even as a woman.

But as something older.

Something remembered.

Something returned.

* * *

The heretics called them Shamans.

The believers called them Mediums.

The realists called them Psychologists.

All of them called her Miss Angelique.

She had other names, too —

Whispered ones, in places where the veil ran thin —

A Vessel.

An Anchor.

A Seer.

Acknowledgments & Afterword



Writing *21 Mirrors* wasn't just a project.

It was a pilgrimage.

Each chapter mirrored a part of me I once tried to silence —
the child who flinched, the woman who stayed,
the dreamer who drowned in grief and still came up gasping
for meaning.

Some mirrors cut deep. Some offered light.

All of them changed me.

To the souls who shaped this journey — knowingly or
otherwise — thank you.

To the ones who cracked me open — I forgive you.

To the readers who found a whisper of their own ache in
these pages — I honor you.

To Mum — the spine I leaned on, even when I couldn't say it
aloud.

To Papa — for the silent supporter who always cheered me
on.

To Didi — for teaching me the language of fierce resilience.

To Dobby and Lisa — the softest goodbyes I never stopped
grieving.

21 Mirrors

To him — whose name I won't write, but whose echo
threaded this book together.

And to the one I was before I began writing this —

You made it.

You wrote it all the way home.

Thank you for reading this spell, this scream, this slow
remembering.

In some world, some mirror,

I hope it healed you too.

— **D. Taskhedkar**

Start Your Journey Inward



If any part of this book mirrored something tender within you...

If you found yourself seen, stirred, or searching for more—
know that you don't have to hold it all alone.

I offer space.

Soft, sacred, human space.

For the ones who feel too much, or not enough.

For the ones who are healing.

You're welcome to reach out,

whether it's a whisper or a full story waiting to unfold.

Just scan the code below to begin.

Reading on your phone or Kindle?

Just take a screenshot of the QR code and open it in Google
Lens - you'll get a direct link.

See you on the other side.



And if this book found your soul, leave a light on for the others.

We're gathering on Instagram, @talesbydt - quietly, wildly, exactly on time :)

To You—The Final Reflection



Thank you.

For reading.

For feeling.

For staying.

Books don't exist without readers. And healing doesn't happen without witnessing.

So thank you for letting this story be both — a book, and a mirror.

May it leave a light on in your chest.



About the Author



D. Taskhedkar is a soul-scriber, therapist, and eternal seeker of the unseen. Her work lives at the intersection of psychology and mysticism, where logic meets longing and stories become medicine.

She believes healing is rarely linear, often messy, and always sacred.

When she isn't writing or holding space for others, she's painting quiet revolutions in her studio, brewing poems with her grief, and whispering back to the universe that made her.

This is her first book.

But she's always been writing.